Drive

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32230936.

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Mature

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Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

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Most of the gang is in here, No Character Death, Angst, hurt sandwich, Fluff, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting, this hurts but trust me I don't want to spoil in the tags, i said trust me, Modern Era, Mid 2000s, Inspired by the Mad ones, Hurt/Comfort, The goal is to make you feel things, im not gonna hurt you like this without after care, This isn't pain for pain sake

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by RaptorRed

Summary

Adora has always had a hard time making choices, but Catra has always been there to help her through high school. Adora is faced with a hard one now as she leaves for college. Catra helps her make the right decision, and helps her heal in the process.

There were two choices that were easy to make though: 1. Buying Catra's car. 2. Never giving up.

Notes

There's some time skips, it should be pretty clear once you get into the meat of the fic. This prologue takes place after the rest of the story. Enjoy.

See the end of the work for more notes

Chances

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The forces that be are against her today. Adora had gotten out of class early to get ready for the soccer match tonight. Of course it was when she'd already gotten back to the dorm that she realized she'd left her other bag, the one she kept her class notes in, in the lecture hall. It's a wonder her shoulder didn't ache. At least she could take Melog to the parking garage next to the pitch rather than having to sprint there too. Melog however decided that it was a good time to notify her with a red light on the dash that it was time for an oil change. Just another thing to add to her already busy schedule. Oh, and she'd left her phone in the car.

That old Lincoln Continental was a lot more temperamental with her than it was with Catra. There was one time Adora swore the door locked itself. One expensive bill later, Adora had three copies of that key made. One for Bow and Glimmer, and one extra for her dorm. It reminded her of a cat pissy its owner was gone. Thus Melog, the stupid name that Catra had always wanted to call their cat. Hopefully she wouldn't be too annoyed her motorized baby claimed it first. Cat always said that engine purred.

Now she was struggling with her socks refusing to keep snug around her calves the way she liked and warm ups were just minutes away. To top it off, her iPod was frozen. It wouldn't turn off, pause, skip, nothing. Just stuck on the same melancholy song, playing over and over again. Yes, exactly what she needed to get the blood pumping for this game. Adora pulled the earbuds out with a sigh, submitting to the cacophony of noises of the locker room.

She had so much homework to do this weekend, and if they won this match, more games to prepare for. A break, she just wished the world would cut her a god damn break. This was not how her

first semester of college was supposed to go. Adora pushed off of the bench and opened her locker. She tucked the useless iPod back in her pack, and instead eye'd the one person that could make her feel better.

The photo was wrinkled because it was just a paper copy. The real one is safely framed in her dorm room. Catra's mouth is open wide, laughing with Adora draped across her back. Their fingers are laced together, balled tight in front of them. Catra's wearing that same plaid shirt that she asked Adora out in. Her lucky shirt she called it, because it had to have been luck that Adora didn't tell her to piss off. That's what she made up anyway, but Adora knew the truth, and so did Cat. If Catra hadn't declared her love for it so much, Adora would have stolen it in a heartbeat. No it wouldn't fit her, but that wouldn't have stopped her. It hung in her closet now. A lot of her dorm space had become a haven for Catra's things, though a few boxes were still tucked away in the Moons' basement. Adora had dug that shirt and a bunch of Catra's things out of the trash late at night. Cold and snow be damned, she wasn't going to let Beatrix throw Catra away like that. She was going to want at least some of those things again.

She pressed her forehead against the paper, pressing until the cold of the steel seeped through to her skin.

"Swooning over your girlfriend again, Grey?" Huntara called out behind her, loudly so the rest of the team could hear.

"So when will she actually show up for a match, huh?" Starla said teasingly a few lockers down.

Adora knew what they all thought. It was strange that this girl she always carried a picture of, this beautiful woman that she never spoke much about with her nosey teammates, never called or came to cheer from the stands. Even the teammates with long distance partners had their other halfs show up to one game.

There was a bet running about this *girlfriend* . They had been high school sweethearts, tragically split before Adora left for

college. This *Catra* girl didn't think they'd last so far apart and that their striker couldn't move on. It explained why Adora was the only freshman that showed up late for summer training, she was too busy dealing with her heartbreak. Then there was the theory that they'd never dated at all. She was the gal Adora never had the guts to tell. A few people, mainly Huntara, just thought that Catra was just a friend, and that Adora was lying about the relationship to keep people from asking her out.

Adora couldn't exactly blame them for not believing her. She hardly ever talked about Catra with them. Keeping it to "she's my girlfriend." and remaining tight lipped at the questions they shot her. What pissed her off though was the running theme in most of these theories was that Adora was delusional and holding on to someone that wasn't there. In not so many words, it was exactly what Hope, her mother, thought too.

She wasn't delusional. Adora liked her odds. Today might be a train wreck already, the entire rest of her life could be a disaster and she still liked her odds; 3%. Approximately the same percentage of teammates that believed Adora. Lonnie only believed her because they were from the same high school. She'd graduated a year before, never actually got to see them date, but they all played soccer together. Lonnie and Catra had a tenuous relationship at best. Their former, and now Adora's current teammate hadn't been there, but she knew. When you're from a small town, news from home travels far. Starla had tried to draw it out of her, but Lonnie kept her mouth shut.

"How bout this Grey." Huntara said as she leaned against the locker next to Adora's. She didn't look toward her, instead she took in the shape of Catra's smile. The way her canines stuck out ridiculously far. "If I get more saves than you get chances-" Adora flexed her hand, remembering the warmth of her fingers, how slender and strong they were. Catra's fit so perfectly between her fingers. If she'd stayed home at least Adora could still have that, could hold her hand. "-we're going to give that girl a call and-" She wouldn't be forgetting the shape of her palm. Catra's fingertips were probably smooth now. Over break, she was going

to be able to visit even more often than she had at the beginning of summer, now that she had a car. Everyday between semesters she'll go, just to sit and talk to her, press her lips against Catra's palm.

"Huntara, drop it." Lonnie said from somewhere behind her.

Adora closed her eyes and rocked back and forth slightly on her feet, feeling her shoes grind against the tile. They left the school dance early, just so they could actually dance together without word getting back to their parents. At least they had been able to dance together at team functions in high school, the team and their friends were safe. If she couldn't tune them out with her iPod, she'd play the music in her head. If she was lucky, maybe even hear the ukulele start ringing through the locker room. It would be nice to see her today. It had been a while, not since Adora's first week of classes.

She was in Glimmer's basement, her hands firmly rested on Catra's waist. It was the last time they danced together. Catra just got her acceptance letter. She knew Cat would get in. They'd both panicked about it at some point. After Adora got scouted, Catra refused to make any more paper doll dreams with Adora, she had to take every tangible moment and hold onto it. She didn't need to do that now. They could imagine a million different futures. They were celebrating, celebrating Catra doing what they all knew she could do. Glimmer let Adora decorate the basement. Perfuma baked Catra a cake. She didn't know just how many people were rooting for her, believed in her. Catra had a hard time accepting it sometimes, but there was no doubt that night.

Adora hummed to herself, let her feet shift to the rhythm of the music. Catra tugged playfully on her arm. She was vaguely aware of Lonnie yelling. They shouldn't be fighting right before a game. She shouldn't be thinking so much of Cat before trotting on the pitch, but today just sucked. This week sucked. Her teammates sometimes made it impossible to push this down. Adora leaned into the press of Catra's head against her cheek. They would get to dance like this again, next summer maybe. She would take

Catra to that restaurant in New Orleans she found and together they would walk barefoot on the beach after. She'd leave the car doors open so they could listen to the stereo, and they would dance again. At least she was going to hang out with Glimmer and Bow after the game. Once the grass stuck to her cleats, she'd be fine to tuck this away, able to live only for the ball for the next 90 minutes.

"Ladies!" Adora stopped moving mid sway, but beyond acknowledging that sounds were happening, she couldn't focus on the words Coach was forming. Instead she just stared at the crinkled paper taped to her locker. It didn't really matter what her teammates thought. Adora could be that crazy ex. She's fine with them thinking her a liar, or creep. They could call her one of the mad ones, completely off her rocker. Maybe she was mad, because who in their right minds bets their heart on 3%?

Chapter End Notes

In no particular order, here is the playlist. The first song is in there to replace a song that Catra makes up and is a bit of a running joke in the fic, because it's funny.

https://open.spotify.com/playlist/4jsWwRLB5aWr5vId1HcydQ?si=RPuS49-tR4GRr68vmEjJ6g&dl_branch=1

Choices

Adora rested her backpack gingerly against the small pile of her carefully packed life sitting in her front yard. She counted the boxes and bags once more, mentally double checking that she'd grabbed everything she'd need. Hopefully it would all fit in the trunk. There wasn't much of what she'd packed that she'd be willing to part with. Micha and Angella stored some of her things, but what little she'd salvaged was precious. The pillow, blanket and ukulele could sit in the back. It would be a pain to have to pull out the bedding if she did end up needing it. That was still undecided.

As upset as her mom was to not be able to send her off, Adora was glad that Hope was away at a conference. Her mother was under the impression that Glimmer and Bow were driving her, not that she had the means to take herself. She'd find out eventually, about the car, but for now she just wanted it to be hers. For today, it was just for her and their memories.

She pulled out her phone from her pocket and flipped it open. 8:28 am, Glimmer and Bow should be here soon. They'd been hiding it for her since she bought it. Well, since she'd given Glimmer the money to buy it. There was no way Beatrix "the bitch" Weaver would have sold it to her. Adora could have offered her double the amount and she still would have said no.

The sound of gravel shifting under tires made her pop her head up. That ole maroon Lincoln Continental crawled its way up until the trunk was somewhat aligned with her pile. Bow's Jeep followed just behind. She saw the driver struggle to get the door open. The handle was fickle, you had to pull it just right. It didn't take her too much longer to shove her way out. Adora's breath caught when a mix of purple and pink hair appeared on the other side of the car. What was she expecting really?

Glimmer dangled the keys in the air, waving them victoriously as she started walking toward the trunk to open it up. "Here she is.

All yours.” Bow hopped out of his jeep too, hands immediately stuffed awkwardly into his pockets as he approached. The halfhearted smile on his face made it obvious that he still didn’t quite know what to say. He’d be acting stiff like this since he picked Adora up from the hospital the day before.

“Let us help you pack it up?” Bow asked hopefully. Things hadn’t really gotten less weird between them in the past few months. They didn’t really know what more they could do for Adora. Glimmer and Bow were hurting too but it’s not like Adora could offer them any comfort. She knew that she hadn’t been a good friend lately, but they both were to her. Unlike Hope, they didn’t pressure her to try and return to normal because things weren’t normal. Her mom just wanted her to be successful, to be happy, but didn’t really understand how to actually help her get there. To be fair, she didn’t know either, and didn’t want things to feel “normal” again. Not until Cat was back.

The trunk was full, her map quest directions were folded and in order in the passenger seat and now the keys were in her hand. All of the keychains were still there, the little pick she’d gotten Catra when she’d gotten her driver’s license, the plastic casing on the key scratched from when Adora threw them into the woods just to keep her around longer. Catra had been pissed off of course, but you just can’t tell a girl you’ve been crushing on for years that you like her now could you? It was the only play Adora had thought of at the time, and it had bought her an extra grumpy fifteen minutes with her Catra.

Adora tensed as a pair of arms wrapped around her from behind and squeezed. She relaxed quickly when she realized it was Bow and dropped her hands to her sides. Glimmer stepped towards her once Adora acknowledged her to complete the goodbye sandwich.

“Call us, and we’ll come early.” Glimmer whispered into her shoulder. Adora hugged her tight, resting one hand on Bow’s arm that was now around his girlfriend's shoulder. They’d be up at the university soon, but Adora was still going to miss them.

“If you change your mind at any point, Glim and I will drive out and one of us will ride in the car with you, okay?” Adora merely nodded, but she had to do this alone. They didn’t know what her actual plan was, if she even followed through with it. It wasn’t something Adora did. Grey did as she was asked, as she was expected. Extra work? Adora was there. Chance for more practice? Count on Grey.

“We can stay a while if you want.” Glimmer offered as they pulled away. Adora shot her gaze up as she heard the familiar bounce of a boot off a rubber. Catra sat there on the hood, one leg dangling, heel bouncing off the tire as she swung her legs, waiting for the wonder duo to leave.

They were all in as little clothes as possible to combat the heat, but Catra was still wearing the same outfit she’d been in that night. Black leather jacket, black jeans, thick,dark, tan boots, and her ‘aesthetically’ ratty red ‘vintage’ Queen shirt she’d found thrifting. Adora really did like that shirt on her, it fit her personality well. Soft, rough around the edges, a royal brat. Catra is going to be crushed when she finds out it was trashed. The paramedics had to cut it off her.

“No, its okay. Thank you though, guys... really.” There was someone else here to talk to, someone she needed to talk to. Adora waved goodbye at them as Bow drove off. Catra waited patiently as she took a moment to gather herself before walking to the car. She slid further to the door and patted the hood for Adora to join her.

“I can’t believe you let Sparkles drive my baby.” Catra said with a sigh as Adora joined her on the hood, the metal popping a little underneath her. Adora twirled the keys in her hand, not sure what to say next. How do you start a conversation with your girlfriend who’s not there?

“So where are you headed, now that you finally took my first love?” They’d been doing this for a while now, but it still usually took Catra a few tries to get Adora start talking. She didn’t need

much coaxing today though. Adora had her chance the day before, and couldn't do it, not to the real her. Adora would never say goodbye, because she didn't need to. There was something about this trip, this plan that told her this would be the last time Adora saw this Catra, for a while anyway. She needed to say... but did she really? What if… She could clear out the passenger seat..

"Oh hell no, I'm not riding shotgun in my own car, Princess." Catra said softly, lips moving close to Adora's ear. She moved to take Adora's hand but stopped, slipping it safely back onto her lap. Catra laced her fingers together, twiddling her thumbs to keep from reaching out again. "Okay, maybe I can swing it, if you tell me where we're headed."

"Away." Adora didn't even need to look up to know that Catra was arching a brow at her, but she did anyway. "Don't give me that. You're not even here, you're not allowed to judge me."

"So?" Catra slid off the side of the car, taking a few steps forward before turning on her heel dramatically. She curled her hand under her chin, and tapped her foot. Every face she made was wildly overplayed as she assessed Adora. She swooped down a few times, nodding her head, and saying a few, "Oh yes, daddy like. Yes, that is a fine figure." that has Adora burying her head in her hands. Catra mimed scribbling on a notepad, even going as far as tapping the imagined pen on her chin.

"Stop trying to make me laugh Cat, this is hard, okay?"

"No." Catra tapped her foot a few more times before flourishing, ripping a page out of the actual notepad that had appeared in her hands. Tossing the notepad into the yard she moved until one hand was on both sides of Adora, trapping her between them. Adora glanced at the paper Catra pressed into the hood. Through her sprawled fingers she saw a 9/10 scribbled across the page.

Adora scoffed as she looked back up, only to find her breath refused to return to her. All she could see were sky and autumn eyes that Adora knew so well she could still see the way the hues

changed as light filtered through them. Her lips were so close, their noses almost pressed together. If Catra were here Adora would smash the tips of their noses together, cup her face and pull her close. Catra made the cutest faces whenever she tried to retreat from an Adora squish attack.

"It would be ten out of ten you know." Catra didn't falter, still boring her gaze right through Adora. Like she could see through her. "But my girl won't tell me why I'm here this time. So it's nine."

Adora shut her eyes, killing the urge to kiss her again. "I'm supposed to leave for college today."

"In July? Why so soon?" She sounded further away, so Adora opened her eyes again and sure enough Catra was a few paces back, waiting patiently for an explanation.

"Soccer, early team training." It felt like her heart was going to beat out of her chest. "Well, training starts in a few weeks, but the coach wants all the freshmen who can, to be there early."

"What a good girl you are, throwing away your summer." Catra said bitterly. "Always so responsible, headed away to school, let me guess, you're also gonna get a summer class in too? So you can be that big shot lawyer, doctor or whatever mommy wants you to do even sooner huh?"

She'd heard this spiel a time or two before. Glimmer always thought that Catra was being a bitch when she got like this. Glimmer didn't know though how often Catra had to comfort her when it was hard to breathe. She didn't know Catra would sneak out of her house, climb through her window when Adora was crying and a phone call wasn't enough. Glimmer didn't know about the pennies they scraped to buy minutes in order to talk each other to sleep.

"But what if I didn't go?" Adora's jaw tightened, the hood popping as she shifted on the metal. "What if I just went to all those

places we talked about?”

“Adora!” Catra gasped and placed a hand over her own heart. “Don’t scare me like that. What a twist! Are you actually going to choose something for yourself for once?”

A smile crept over her face. She loved this snarky girl so much. “Hey! I bought this car didn’t I?”

“We both know that wasn’t a choice.” Catra smiled back at her. They stood there for a while, just watching. This was it, the car was packed. She had directions to the dorms in her passenger seat. She didn’t want to follow them though, she wanted to drive to the Grand Canyon, she wanted to find a lookout and lay in the grass with Cat, fall asleep under the stars and hunger for a truck stop coffee and shower with her in the morning. The car was packed, but only as half as it should be.

“What are you waiting for then Adora?” She opened her mouth to answer but the words melted away, like ice, freezing her thoughts. She was waiting for Catra, she couldn’t leave her behind.

“I don’t know if I can. I don’t know-” if I can leave you. “ if I can just not drive straight to the college.”

“ *Come on* .” Catra gestured to the car as she approached the back seat. “ *Get in, Adora* .”

“But.. *Catra, I can’t just skip* the freshman to the-I need to get-”

“ *Get in, loser.* ”

—-

“Come on. Get in, Adora.” Catra called out the window to a very cranky blonde who already had her practice gear on.

“Catra.” She growled without looking toward the maroon Lincoln that was creeping alongside her as she power walked down the sidewalk. “I can’t just skip practice. We have a match coming up and you shouldn’t either. Coach is already pissed at you.”

“Oh boo hoo. It’s the beginning of our Senior year and you still haven’t skipped school once. What kind of teenager are you?” Adora was pretty sure Catra heard the grumbled reply of ‘a responsible one’ but she breezed right past it. “Besides, I’m talking all day, beautiful, not just practice.” They were only a few blocks away from the school at this point, Catra had been following her for the last fifteen minutes. At first she thought Catra had swung by as usual so they could ride together, just a block away from the house so Hope didn’t think she was with *that girl* again. Adora had taken her seat, kissed her girlfriend good morning but then Catra had said “Skip with me.” so sweetly, prompting Adora to grab her bag and start walking.

“I figured Cat, and the answer is still no.” If she was honest with herself, it was very tempting. Free time with Catra without having to worry about a call to the Moon’s house from her mother at any given moment. Time spent *alone* , no kissy noises from Glim being thrown at them. The little alone time they got was always precious, and this one wouldn’t have to involve an elaborate plot with the help of their friends.

Catra threw her head back and sighed. She’d tried blasting guilt tunes for part of the journey, Don’t Go Breaking My Heart, Candle In The Wind, she even had managed to burn the new Almost Lover on the cd she’d prepared for today. Not even laying on fake, thick heartbreak cracked the sap. She knew it wasn’t going to be easy, and Adora was a sucker for her dramatics but it seemed her hard headed girlfriend was extra steely today. “Fine. Get in loser.”

Adora stopped and glared at her suspiciously. “What do you mean fine?”

“Fine, as in we’ll go to practice. If I can’t steal you for a romantic getaway I at least want to spend time with you before we get all

sweaty and then dragged to class.” Adora’s suspicion didn’t waver as she opened up the door and tossed her bags into the back seat.

Catra rolled her eyes, but Adora could tell that she was actually upset. Catra tried not to be, she knew asking Adora for this was a long shot, but it still stung. Adora dropped her glare and grabbed Catra’s hand. “Hey, you know I love you right?”

Foot still pressed down against the brake pedal she turned in her seat and looked into beautiful blue eyes. She did know that, and she also loved Adora. Adora, who was wound tight, afraid to break the rules, not because she didn’t want to get in trouble, but because she didn't want to disappoint anyone. Adora who broke some of them anyway, despite the anxiety it gave her, just to be with Catra. Adora who used to not be able to lie to save her life, but learned to just so they could spend time together. Adora who was pouting so cutely.

“Yeah, I know.” Catra pressed a kiss to her cheek, she stayed there until she felt that rosy muscle tighten up into a smile. “I love you too.”

“We can make out right until practice?” Adora whispered into her ear, voice gravelly. Catra whipped her head around, checking for traffic. Not many people about in this small town at six in the morning. Her passenger let out a squeak when she slammed her foot on the gas. If she pulled right up to the field that would give them a good fifteen, twenty minutes.

Adora was in heaven, Catra’s hand resting on her waist under her practice jersey. It was a good thing both of them didn’t have their practice gear on, it would’ve been a lot more uncomfortable for Catra to climb in her lap with shin guards on. While fingers tantalized her skin, Adora ran hers through Catra’s short, wavy, brown locks. She moaned as Catra pulled back, her lip still trapped between her teeth.

“We should-” Catra started, but ended up laughing into Adora’s lips when she dragged her back, sliding her arms down to encircle her and crushing their bodies together. Adora never wanted this to end, but of course a knock separated them once more. Catra bent awkwardly to roll down the foggy window, revealing an amused Glimmer standing outside of the car.

“Do the dos randy lesbians plan on actually coming to practice or are you gonna make us pretend to not see the car rocking?”

“How was breakfast?” Catra replied, her head rested on Adora’s shoulder with a shit eating grin.

Glimmer growled at her. “If you start singing that stupid song again, I swear-“

“Relax Sparkles. We’re getting out right-“

“No.” Adora blurted out, much to her own surprise. She wrapped her arms tighter around Catra to keep her from leaning back in shock of her own. “Can you tell the coach when she gets here that I’m sick?” Damn, what about Cat? “Or, actually that you passed us and saw us with a flat tire?”

Catra wiggled as she spoke, trying to break free. It was hard to get any power with her arms tucked under Adora’s. Catra turned her head to change strategies, nipping lightly on her neck. Adora choked back a garbled noise of surprise and unwillingly relaxed her grip.

“Really?” Catra finally got to ask, eye to eye with her girlfriend. She didn’t want to hold onto the hope that bubbled up if Adora didn’t seem sure. There was still apprehension under those thick eyebrows, but there was something else too. The same look she has in her eyes when they would crawl out of Adora’s window together. Thank god for that tree, and it’s perfect branches. Catra had never loved a tree so much in her life.

“Yeah, really.” Adora smiled as if she couldn’t believe the words herself, like they were old friends she’d run into by chance.

Catra turned back to Glimmer who looked about ten seconds away from walking off, bored with the queer nonsense that was happening in front of her. “Not a flat.” Catra said seriously. “We’re skipping all day. You saw smoke, stopped to see what was up and now Adora and I are pushing it to a shop.” They weren’t really worried about the rest of the team ratting them out, not after Adora took all the blame for the impromptu hotel party at the final away game last season. Even though her and Catra weren’t even present for it, they were too busy staying up late, talking about whatever... back when they were still just pining for each other.

“You both owe me, big time.” Glimmer said smugly, finger pointed down at them.

“No, I don’t think I do,” Catra said matter of factly as she shimmied off of Adora’s lap, attempting to settle herself back into the driver's seat in the cramped car. It was no easy feat, but Catra had gotten a lot of practice when the backseat was out of the question. “What was it I walked in on… oh that’s right.” Glimmer groaned and turned on her heels, heading onto the field. “Sparkles-“ Catra sang out, turning the key in the ignition. “-eats Bow for breakfast-“

She felt buzzed, like she’d had a beer. Adora hadn’t felt this naughty, this wild, since the basement party they had at the end of their junior year. Skipping school, skipping practice, thinking about having been drunk once, dating, dating *Catra.* All these things Hope would be so upset by if she found out. Okay, dating was iffy, any girl, any girl that wasn’t Catra would be better, but still! Who was this person? Dr. Adora Grey, surgeon, star soccer player and peace prize winner, wouldn’t do things like this. None of these actions ever fit in the timeline Hope had laid out for her, this was in none of the paths that were given to her as an option. Catra had a knack for pulling her down corridors that she didn’t even know existed. That’s what drew her to Catra at first, how she just did her own thing no matter what anyone said. Adora had never, ever, considered it as a valid option, and here she was now, skipping school!

She reached over and squeezed Catra's thigh excitedly. They were at a stop light, so it wasn't that unsafe to do. "Okay Cat, where are we going, babe? Oooh I'm so excited!"

Catra chuckled and caught her hand, pulling it up to kiss her knuckles. "Hold your horses Princess, and take off your shin guards so your legs don't get all sweaty.

"I'll do that when we get there. Now tell me, where is my lovely lady taking me while we play hooky?"

Catra shrugged. "No clue." That brought the bubbly feeling to a halt, a rock taking its place at the pit of her stomach. "We could drive to the pier?" Catra turned and flashed her teeth at her once again tense passenger. "Maybe Yellowstone? Go see Ole Faithful?"

"Yellowstone is like..." Adora scrunched her brows together, she didn't really need to guess because it was out of the question but couldn't help herself. "Four? No, five days drive Cat. The pier would take all day."

Her tongue was sticking out, trapping it to keep from snickering. It was still way too easy to get her worked up. "Adora, come on? Does it matter where we're going? We could go anywhere today. Pick a direction."

"Well I thought you had a plan! You didn't have a plan beyond kidnapping me?"

"I do have a plan! Now I do anyway, and that's for you to pick a direction Princess. This road is gonna end eventually, would hate to have to hop the curb into somebody's house."

"Why me?" Catra ignored her and turned the radio on. Adora sat, staring silently. Catra started to whistle along with the radio. 'If she wants to play this game, she's going to lose'; went through both of their minds.

"Man, I'm hungry." Catra said nonchalantly, waving at one of the few fast food joints open this hour as they drove by.

“Then why didn’t you pull in?” Adora asked as if she didn’t care the least bit, as if her stomach wasn’t growling either.

“You didn’t tell me to.” This lasted for about five more minutes, Adora’s stomach growling loudly at the chance for food, exasperated by the only increasing distance between her and said breakfast. “Turn around.” Adora finally relented, facing out the passenger window. She was not going to let Catra’s satisfied mug grace her vision.

Catra grew worried as Adora continued to ignore her, silently taking her food out of the bag, munching away angrily. She didn’t want to upset her, not really. It was fun to tease but those broad shoulders kept rising higher as Adora pulled into herself more and more. When Adora actually relaxed, took that leap into something unknown, she really shined. Catra saw the girl she’d fallen in love with years ago finally look carefree. Sometimes Catra pushed it too far, and this might have been one of those times.

Yeah, she liked being a bit of a thorn in her side to begin with, Adora needed someone in her life like that, but sometimes Catra crossed a line from supportive girlfriend, to trying to fix her. It was a problem both of them had. If Adora was like this for the rest of her life, Catra could, and would feel lucky to live with that. It wasn’t Adora’s fault, and it didn't need *fixed* per say, but it was hard knowing the reason why she was like that. Just how much goofier would her girl be if she’d been allowed to be a kid? Catra could relate, but her mother had given up on trying to influence her, and instead just punished or ignored her. At least though, Catra knew she could do whatever she wanted because it didn't really matter what she did, the end result was always the same.

Adora brought a bit of order to her life, gave her dreams to look forward to, pushed her to strive for what she’d always been told she’d never accomplish. Adora believed in her, Catra wanted to return the favor. She just wanted Adora to be able to see the world as a beautifully free place, not a destination with an allotted amount of time allowed before getting back to business.

If Catra's mother was bad, Adora's was the exact polar opposite. Including the toxicity. They were opposite ends of the same horseshoe. Ever since Hope adopted her at 6, every moment of Adora's life was on the calendar that hung by her front door. Even her future, all the way to her mid twenties was planned out for her in a big planner somewhere. Exactly two hours of free time each evening, even in the summer. It was the only reason Catra joined the soccer team their sophomore year. A promise of more time together.

It was a good thing Glimmer put on a respectable mask around adults. Bow was actually a ray of sunshine so he didn't need to fool anyone. If not for them, the promise that Adora was studying when she went out wouldn't have been enough for Hope. They were the good kids, top of their class. No wonder she hated Catra so much. Well, Catra hated her too. How could she not see what she was doing to Adora? What she had done to Adora? Hope had to know what a big ball of perfection striving anxiety her child was. Then again, maybe she didn't, she probably had never seen Adora truly relax around her in years.

"Look, Dor." Catra sat her breakfast sandwich down on the dash. The crumbly biscuits weren't going down well in her already dry mouth. "I'm sorry."

Adora took another bite, and still didn't look at her, but her eyes softened a bit.

"I got carried away. How about I give us some options?" Wherever Adora wanted to go, that's where they'd go. That was her plan from the start, she just went about it the wrong way.

It turned out that Adora wasn't too upset with her, leaning over silently when Catra picked her food back up to place a greasy peck on her cheek. She laughed with crumbs flying when Catra wiped her cheek off on Adora's shoulder. When she gave her list of ideas, she knew that the Whispering Woods we're going to win. The whole group camped out there last summer. They almost

kissed there last summer too, only acknowledging that fact after Catra had confessed to her a few months ago.

They stopped at the mart before heading out, grabbing snacks, Catra slipping two mini bottles of wine into her pants. If they were going to be there all day, it was safe to have a little delinquent romance, if Adora wanted to. It was about an hour out of town, and probably the biggest perk of living in the middle of nowhere. The national park was sprawling and out of the way enough that people from the city rarely swarmed it. Even on major holidays, the woods were quiet other than the rustling of leaves in the wind and birds fleeting, calling and cawing. Adora tried to buy a map while they were in the checkout. Catra tossed that thing right back with the gossip mags. "Maps are for braindeads." That got her a well earned huff and mostly likely a future lecture if they did get lost. It was with it though because boy did she love razzing Adora.

They hiked a trail with grocery bags and blanket in tow. Catra became Adora's backpack for a while, simply enjoying the fact that her girlfriend could carry her through rough terrain like this. They stayed there a few hours, cuddling, munching on Cheetos over tiny wine bottles. Adora loved the way Catra's calloused fingertips felt against her skin, nearly tickling, leaving embers in their wake. It almost happened there. Alone in the woods, in the shade of a tree. Catra made a noise, a whimper that filled Adora's heart with more than music. Cat's leg was wrapped so tightly around her own, hands busy with fistfuls of fabric, pulling her closer.

The lewd noise surprised them both, but Catra was more taken aback by how dark Adora's eyes had gotten. Catra kissed her greedily until they were both breathless, she couldn't help herself. Adora's hands were slipping dangerously high up Catra's shorts, squeezing the insides of her thighs, drawing increasingly needy sounds from her lips. Adora was about to ask, Catra waited with held breath as she looked up at this beautiful girl haloed by the light trickling through the tree canopy. She never did ask. Instead, Adora's face grew stony and pale, gaze averted just to Catra's left.

Adora was no longer lost in the world that was Catra, instead she was observing the army of ants that came to collect the crumbs of forgone snacks. The forest had come to collect its payment at exactly the worst time. Nothing kills the mood faster than the prospect of literal ants in your pants.

Catra was busy cursing that colony's Queen on the drive back, wishing death upon their kingdom when Adora told her to turn. They were still nearly twenty minutes from town, little patches of woods spattering their drive. Catra wasn't about to say no, even though they were expected to be gone from school soon.

"Why here?" Catra asked as the engine worked their way up the steep road.

"I don't know." Adora replied eventually. "I guess I just- I just don't want today to end yet."

Catra started laughing, which was confusing as hell to Adora. Her cackling became even more manic as she slowed the car. "Of course- ha- of course you don't know about this place." Adora glared at her. She finally made a spur of the moment decision on this trip, and Catra was making fun of her for it. It became clear to her why Catra was so amused when they pulled up to the outlook. Distant shops and homes were visible, the car neatly tucked away, surrounded by trees. No, she'd seen this kind of place before in many teen romance flicks.

"Oh"

"Yeah , 'oh' Princess." Catra's mockery stopped there when she saw hungry eyes looking at here again.

"Well, since we're here. I suppose we shouldn't let it go to waste." Adora pressed a finger to Catra's lips that we're about to part. She already knew what her smart ass girlfriend was going to say. "And No, *Princess* didn't get enough of you today already." Adora removed her hand and went to turn off the radio, leaning ever closer as the volume went down. Right as Catra moved to close

the gap, there was a crack of plastic breaking. Adora brought the broken radio knob between them with a pained smile.

“What the fuck, Adora?” Catra groaned and closed her eyes. “Just put it in the glove box and get back to kissing me you brute.”

—

Adora leaned over to the passenger side and gave the handle of the glove box a good yank. She’d broken that too. “I swear, this car was solid until you started riding in it.” Catra said from the backseat, lounging with her dirty boots in Adora’s pillow. She’d chastise her for it, but the pillow wouldn’t have a speck of dirt on them anyway, so there wasn’t much point. “That was a really good day.”

She inspected the plastic knob. Catra had tried to glue it back on but nothing stuck. The tiny metal rod that it was covering still worked for the volume well enough.

“You burn any cd’s?” Catra was trying to distract her, but it wasn’t really working. Not when this car had so many memories. She wouldn’t break anything else in this thing, it would be exactly how Catra left it when Adora could give it back, just with a few more thousand miles on it.

“I’m still going to college.” Adora didn’t know why she felt the need to say it, probably because she didn’t want to. She didn’t want to leave this town, she didn’t want to be so far away from her. She didn’t want to see all these places they wrote down in notebooks between class. They made a deal, Catra would buckle down, actually apply for University, because fuck she was smart. In return Adora would go with her on a trip of a lifetime. It didn’t feel right to go without her.

“I know you are. You’re my respectable, responsible sweetheart. The best influence a girl could ask for, but that doesn’t mean you can’t have a little fun first Dor.”

“I don’t know Cat.” The suffocating tightness she’d become all too familiar with returned to her chest. Catra was right there, her voice, her wit…

“Why don’t we just… talk for a while Dor. You don’t have to make a choice right now.”

Calluses

Chapter Notes

> Oops, my hand slipped. (I couldn't wait 2 days it turns out) I'm so pumped for the rest of this to be posted bc it builds in momentum.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She rubbed the pads of her girlfriends still fingers. The calluses were still there, more faded now but still there. Cat always thought it was silly, but she loved the different texture, loved the way they felt against her lips. Adora always loved kissing them when they cuddled up together. Hopefully, Catra would wake up before they were completely gone. She'd be so pissed. She took that thing everywhere.

"Gotta keep playing, these fingers didn't bleed for nothing." Adora smiled to herself before gingerly lifting Catra's arm and hand off the bed slightly. She pressed her lips to Catra's palm, glancing up at her face, still expecting any twitch of a smile. Nothing, just like every time before that.

Adora sighed, resting her arm back down and wove their fingers together. "You were so nervous, you know, it was cute. It freaked me out seeing you like that." Adora had really thought that Catra might hurl. Cool, collected Cat had been shaking like a leaf and for nothing. Of course Adora felt the same. She'd imagined that first kiss for years, finally understanding those giddy girls who crushed after boys in the shows Glimmer had her watch. Catra had her feeling electric every time they accidentally brushed hands at the start of their friendship. The first time they cuddled awkwardly, *platonically,* to all fit on the couch, Adora didn't even remember the movie because her heart was beating so hard. She was so thankful Cat finally gathered the courage.

Adora started to hum. She didn't retain the words the first time. Catra didn't blame her though. In retrospect it was easy to pinpoint the moment when Adora's brain started short circuiting.

Love.

"You remember? The day we finally got together? I'm really glad our friends uh, kind of pushed you into it. They did it to me too a few months before, but you know me. I guess they got fed up with my arguments. I didn't know how to make it perfect." No plan she ever made ever seemed good enough, not good enough for her.

Catra deserved the world and Adora wanted to give it to her. She wanted to make up for all the love that little girl never received. Every hug, every kiss, every 'you're incredible Cat' to bury the constant scorn that little girl never deserved. It might take a lifetime, so she better wake up soon, so that Adora could keep giving it to her.

"But you, you did it perfectly."

Carefully, Adora placed the beers on the center of the perfectly spaced coasters on the table they'd hauled into Glimmers basement. Why was she like this? It didn't matter, it still made her cock an amused smile. Every dorky thing Adora did seemed to get that reaction out of her.

Catra leaned against the painted pale blue concrete wall and cleared her throat. Adora straightened herself, wiping the sweat from the cans off her hands with her hoodie. Catra's hoodie. It

was a good thing she always liked them a size up. The girl was addicted to tank tops even though she knew the Moon's basement was always a few degrees cooler. Catra appreciated the tank tops though, they really showed off those arms that Catra kept finding more and more excuses to touch.

"You do know that those are going to be moved around like, 30 seconds after people get here right?" Adora shrugged.

"I just want it to look nice." She said meekly, staring at the cans on the table. Adora was nervous, she'd never been to a party let alone drank before. This wasn't a party really, just a group of friends taking advantage of a parent free home while Micha and Angella Moon were away for their anniversary.

Somehow her idiot found a way to freak out about the fact that she'd never tasted an " *adult"* beverage. Catra told her she'd never *have* to but she wanted to try it. Adora didn't want to stick out like a sore thumb in college, a repeat of when she started high school here. She'd felt very out of place after years of homeschooling and private tutors. If this was another lesson in fun Catra could provide, she would. Better here and now, safe, than at some frat party alone. Plus their Junior year just ended. There was plenty to celebrate even though it marked another year closer to Adora going off to a college somewhere out of Catra's reach.

"It does look nice."

"Thanks." Adora nodded as she looked down at the table, approving of her own work. "So uh, how did you get these?" She narrowed her eyes at Catra when her face twisted into a smirk.

"Stole em' from the gas station on 4th." She got the exact reaction from Adora that she was hoping and couldn't help but laugh harder.

"Catra! You could have been arrested! You know that guy already thinks you steal something every time you come in." It wasn't

disappointment, it was well disguised awe blended with a heavy dollop of concern.

“That’s because I do.”

Adora was charging her now. Catra was almost caught, not quite registering what was happening before it was nearly too late. Catra leapt to the side as Adora’s hand smacked against the wall to help her balance for a quick turn. She’d have to run around the table in order to get to the door but Adora would be expecting that. She hurdled over the pile of bean bag chairs in the center.

“You’ve gotten faster.” Adora huffed as Catra whipped around to face her.

“Nah...” Catra analyzed her stance. She’d watched and played with her enough on the pitch to know her next moves. Adora was a master at ball control, often faking out with her shoulders before pulling out a simple step over when the defender’s expected something else. She’d get them with that a few times before switching easily between more complicated moves. Soccer was one of the few activities where she didn’t fumble with decisions. Adora had been playing, practicing every day since she was seven. “I’m just smarter.” Catra launched one of the bags at her and sprinted to the door.

Her foot nearly hit the step when a pair of arms wrapped around her waist, hauling her backwards. Catra pushed down on her arms but they wouldn’t budge. No amount of wiggling worked either. She knew what was coming and unless she wanted to hurt Adora (out of the question) her fate was sealed. Air weazed out of the pile in the middle of the room that was once her last line of defence. Now those stupid chairs were her squishy prison. Catra pressed her feet against those solid thighs but it was too late. Choked laughter filled the basement. Adora was lucky it was her. Bow tried to tickle her once. Once.

She shook and fought, slapping hands away and holding back her kicks as much as possible. Adora didn’t seem phased though. The

edges of her vision started to form white spots. Like hell Catra was going to cry uncle. Every time she reached up, Adora's hand pushed it back down. Once it became clear Catra wasn't going to stop trying to get back at her, Adora grabbed one wrist, pinning it and plopped down on top of the significantly smaller woman. That's just what Catra was waiting for. If she was ticklish Adora was hundred times more. This wasn't her first rodeo against the buff buffoon. Catra finally made contact with her ribs and soon had her squealing. Adora rolled off her and onto the floor for a chance at breath.

They were both huffing for air and grinning at each other. Adora's hair poof was wrecked and Catra's own mop had definitely seen better days. When Catra finally sat back up she discovered that the rest of the party had arrived and or returned from their pizza run, and they were all staring at her. Scorpia didn't have stars in her eyes like the first ten times she'd seen them act like this. Perfuma didn't offer a suggestive smile. Bow didn't beam at her. Glimmer didn't glare. They were all staring at her like she was denser than the poured concrete under the carpet. Individually they'd all talked to her over the last two years about Adora. At least Entrapta was scribbling in her palm pilot as per usual.

One and half beers in, they all agreed that Adora was good for at least the next hour. The lightweight was giggly and tipsy. No one wanted to see her wasted. It wasn't just because they were good friends. Everyone was also afraid of just what kind of animal would be unleashed. She already was hanging off of Catra's every word, and off her shoulder every chance she got. Any more alcohol and Catra would have a much taller, 160lb backpack to carry around.

"I'll be back!" She shouted, hanging from the top of the doorframe. "Gotta peeee." Adora giggled and ran up the stairs. There was no thump at least. If she wasn't back in five Catra was going to go hunt her down. Maybe she should just go now. She turned from the door to set her drink on the table only to see everyone had already started to zero in on her as soon as Adora

left. Everyone here but them were couples. Scorpia and Perfuma, Glimmer and Bow, Entrapta and her heavy ass laptop.

"Don't." Catra crossed her arms and glared at them. Glimmer let out a frustrated sigh.

"Listen Wildcat. You know I love you to bits right?" Scorpia waited, and waited some more for a response but her lips were sealed. "This is an intervention." Catra picked her beer back up and started chugging, not so subtly flipping off Sparkles and Sparkles alone. This was certainly her doing. No way in hell was she having this conversation with them again, especially with all of them ganging up on her.

"She doesn't want me, not like that. It would have happened by now." Bow looked like he was ready to flip the table. Well It was true, Catra would say things to Adora that she'd never say to anyone else, things she said that made her heart pound with hope that the words would finally change things between them.

Like how she wanted to take her all over the world, how Adora was the first and last thing she'd think about every day. "Me too." She'd say or text, quickly followed by some iteration of "You're my best friend Cat." Best friend, just like Glimmer and Bow. Adora wasn't just Catra's best friend. Adora was her moon and stars.

Bow ran his hands through his curly hair in frustration. "Catra! She's been all over you all night! And no, it's not just the alcohol. She's not being self conscious about it for once. Any excuse Adora has to touch you she does. Does she offer to massage Glimmer's legs after practice? No!."

Little bubbles of carbonation, or hope, were collecting in Catra's chest. She shouldn't have chugged that beer. They needed to be popped, right now. "She was touch starved Bow. We're just close okay. Maybe she doesn't do that for Glimmer because she thinks you'd be weird about it?"

Entrapta stepped in front of Bow before he could shake her. She turned to face Catra, a notebook appearing from seemingly nowhere tucked close to her chest. “Catra, we all know that when Adora has a decision to make that’s based on emotion, she weighs some pretty non-scientific odds for her decisions. Her process is surprisingly conventional when it's logic but that’s not the point. When it comes to you, unless you’ve really made her angry, it's unlikely she’d do anything that has any chance to drastically upset you.” Catra blinked at her, waiting for her to finish the thought. “She would never-” Nerd flipped open the magic notebook and scanned down the page. “-make the first move.” Satisfied, Entrapta closed it with a snap.

“Oh! And how do you know that?” She hissed back at the entire group because they were all offering nods of agreement.

“We...” Perfuma played with the seam of her dress, debating. “We can't tell you.” Thunderous steps came back down the stairs, Adora had made it after all. Catra turned to look at her. Adora’s eyes searched the scene and her face turned sour. Catra was obviously tense, her shoulders locked tight. She crossed over to them and wrapped her arm around Catra’s back protectively. She hated how visibly obvious some of that tension melted away at Adora’s touch.

“Oh is it corner Catra time? Not cool.” She really tried to keep her words from emoting the alcohol buzzing inside. Adora rested her chin on Catra’s shoulder, her face softer now. “You okay?” If all of their friends weren’t in front of them she would have jumped out of her skin when Adora placed a gentle kiss on her cheek to follow her question. Top of the head was bad enough but that she’d been used to. Glimmer glared at Catra, daring her to eat her words.

“Oh, she’s just being obstinate, but you *looove* that about her don’t you Adora?” Glimmer asked with a wicked grin.

“Of course I do.” Adora cooed, her sober act quickly forgotten and placed another searing kiss on Catra’s cheek. “I love everything

about Cat.” Adora buried her face in Catra’s hair as she held her head like a ball, tucked into her chest. Adora wasn’t that drunk. She would remember this, plus she could ask her again tomorrow or later tonight. Adora suddenly realized that she had asked an important question and looked down at the squished face she just couldn’t let go of. “Seriously though, you okay?”

“Yeah, I'm just peachy. Hey uh, Adora?” Catra felt dizzy when Adora’s smile returned and hummed in response. “You want to go on a picnic with me this weekend?”

—-

Catra shook her hand out and puffed her cheeks, blowing out a rush of air. She shifted her weight again, adjusting the ukulele once more. It was lower than she usually handled it when she played. Her mouth opened to say something but nothing came out. Instead she was glaring at someone that Adora recognized as one of their classmates, Kyle. He had his hand raised and was headed towards them. He paused when he finally noticed Catra’s death glare. Honestly, Adora was surprised he didn’t catch fire with all the heat Catra was sending him.

Kyle slowly lowered his hand but he didn’t move. Catra looked like she was about to burst a vein.

“Uh.. I’ll uh… say Hi some other time.” He whipped around but Catra didn’t take her eyes off him until his feet were back on the sidewalk.

“You can show me your song somewhere more private if you want Cat.” It was odd, her being this nervous. She loved strumming and belting out in the hallways. There was more than one time she’d followed Adora or Glimmer around, making up words on the fly to tease them. Much to Glimmer’s chagrin “Sparkles eats glitter for breakfast.” was quite catchy. At least it was glitter at school, Bow was the lyric when it was just their friends.

Adora had hummed it absentmindedly a few times much to Catra's delight and Glimmer's fury. It was amazing to her that the two have been friends since kindergarten. They hadn't spent a lot of time together growing up except over the summer, and short stints after school. meeting on bike rides. Catra wanted nothing else but to go to public school like most of the other kids in town. A public school where she wasn't admonished by nuns for not acting like a "proper girl".

Adora understood though why that had all come crashing down once Catra got her wish and they actually started attending the same school. According to everyone Adora had talked to, middle school was bad enough as it is. Throw in Glimmer and Catra spending much more time together… they were too similar, bull headed and mean if you didn't know better.

Catra shook her head. "No, it's a beautiful day, this is a beautiful park and it's perfect for *someone as beautiful as you."* Adora wasn't quite sure if she'd heard the last part of her mumbled growl correctly. She felt her heart flutter, jumping the gun on that jumble of sounds. Catra rubbed the sweat off her forehead with the rolled up sleeve of her red and white plaid button up she'd thrown over her white t-shirt. It was one Adora hadn't seen before. Catra looked like she was about to be sick. New clothes, her unusual silence since Adora had gotten here, there was something wrong. Nope, she- she definitely didn't hear that correctly.

"Catra, what did-" Catra cleared her throat and sat up straight, resting the scratched up ukulele flat on her lap. She rubbed the little rainbow sticker Adora had placed on there her freshman year for good luck before plucking two of the strings, a breath between them. That continued as she slapped the body of the instrument, then her leg. It didn't take her long to find the rhythm in spite of her shaking hands. It reminded Adora of a slow march.

"Hung pictures of patron-" her voice cracked and she stopped, glancing up at her. Adora could feel her palms starting to sweat. Why was Catra acting like this? She started up again, her voice low with gentle lilts in the words. Her head was tucked so far down Adora could barely see her face.

" *saints up on my wall*

To remind me that I am a fool

Tell me where I came from, what I will always be:

Just a rotten little kid who went to Catholic school"

She looked up now, straight into Adora's eyes. Fear danced behind them, uncertainty. Adora wanted to take that fear away from her, but was too nervous herself to move. She didn't want to interrupt her.

"When I am dead, I won't join their ranks

'Cause they are both holy and free

And I'm in love, satanic and gay

And until the end, that's how it'll be"

Adora went stiff. In love?

If there was any time Catra wished she could get lost in Adora's eyes it was now. She was trying to, trying to make it clear with her words. It was a song she wrote over two years ago now, a

song that came to her one morning that just wouldn’t get out of her head. That was when Catra knew Adora had changed her.

“I said "You made me love myself, so that I might love you"

Don't make me a liar, 'cause I swear to God

When I said it, I hoped it was true.”

She knew she’d still probably have to spell it out for the dummy, but the look in Adora’s eyes when Catra said love, there was at least something there, the wheels that were spinning were hopefully on the right track. If she didn’t feel the same, it would be okay because at least the words were true. Catra wasn’t sick, wasn’t wrong. Logically, she always knew that, but Adora made her believe it. Adora made her look in the mirror and actually like what she saw. If golden Adora Grey, of all people, could look fondly at this bratty, snarky, gay girl, then Catra could too.

“Saint Calvin told me not to worry about you

But he's got his own things to deal with

There's really just one thing that we have in common:

And I hope it will be this.”

She strummed now instead of plucked, aggressive against the strings, punching her thigh for a harder sound. Catra raised her voice to a reserved yell, doing her best to create the sound she needed without drawing the eye of every passerby.

"A Saint Bernard sits at the top of the driveway

You always said how you loved dogs

I know I don't count, but this Cat's trying her best

When I'm yowling and singing these songs"

Catra's hand flew up to cover her own mouth. With the last note still in the air she looked away from Adora, staring at the plastic laundry basket she'd packed their picnic in. Adora wasn't sure how much time had passed, her focus solely on the words spinning in her head and on the girl trembling in front of her.

Adora's head was reeling, not quite sure if she should let herself believe the words, believe the fact that this whole set up seemed a touch on the romantic side. Catra looked so adorable in her new flannel and carefully groomed hair, there was Adora's favorite snacks packed…and then Catra said… *so that I may love you.*

Catra, the girl she had a crush on since Adora had moved here freshman year.

Catra, the woman she dreaded sharing a locker room with because it was so hard to not look.

Catra, the person who dragged her into the outside world, a world where grades, performance and success wasn't Adora's sole purpose in life.

Catra, who she was in love with.

Catra, who loved her.

"Cat…? You-you love me?" Adora didn't know if she said it loud enough, distracted by the pulsing in her ears and the coil around

her chest. She forced the words past the rocks in her throat."Or was that just the song?" Please let it be the first one. Please let these be words meant for her. Catra sniffled behind her hand and dropped it limp on to her lap.

Tears streamed down Catra's face, lips pressed tight trying to stop herself from crying any harder.

"I love you, idiot." Catra choked out and started to move to get up, turning away from her. She was going to run as far away from here as possible. Stupid Glimmer, Scorpia, Bow, all of them. Adora quickly snatched her wrist and pulled lightly before she could get off of her knees. Catra didn't resist. She didn't want to run from Adora, not if Adora still wanted her around. After her only ever going to be a best friend said that she'd still be her friend anyway (hopefully) Catra could run just a little, as a treat, to pick up the pieces of her broken heart. Catra swung around and there was Adora, meeting Catra in the middle of the quilt. Blue eyes inches from hers.

"I love you too."

The universe could have imploded around them and neither of them would have noticed. She watched Adora, her face looking just as stunned as Catra felt. Four words she never thought she'd hear. Catra leaned forward, basically falling on her as she cupped her face and kissed the girl of her dreams for the first time. A kiss they'd both spent far too much time dreaming about. Adora let Catra meld into her, wrapping an arm tight around Catra's lean form and didn't intend on letting her go any time soon.

Their first kiss was salty from Catra's tears. Something they brought up often because it was the first thing Adora said when they finally parted. Catra loved to tease her about it. Their friends had no idea why it was so funny to them. After they finally parted that first time, Adora rubbed her lower lip and whispered it like it was some big secret. "Salty." Once Catra's laughter started to die down Adora pulled her back into their second. Adora wasn't going to say anything dorky at the end of that one.

“Salty.” Catra whispered back, laughing in joy and disbelief against her lips.

Adora glanced at the clock on the wall. She had time still. She was going to wait until the very last second, maybe even later. The nurses ignored visitation hours for her. Adora could pull the curtains and watch the sunset together.

During the first twenty four hours, Beatrix had tried to storm in and take over, ban anyone from coming in, barking orders. The worst thing Adora had ever done was give the hospital Catra’s home number so they could contact *family.* That woman was less family to Cat than any of her friends. Beatrix played the part of the concerned and grief ridden mother. Catra was 19 but her mother, Adora hated calling her that, was her only next of kin. They sat for hours with an ethics board. All their friends, their friends' parents, even Adora’s own mom surprised her. Ultimately, thankfully the hospital ended up taking over. Turns out Beatrix didn’t care enough to object.

As long as she could breath on her own, as long as her pupils dilated and the little statics of brain activity didn’t decrease, the care plan wouldn’t change. They checked every six weeks. Every six weeks Adora had a panic attack in the waiting room before visiting hours. They couldn’t tell them details, instead the doctor just gave her a thumbs up. She was going to miss the next six week check.

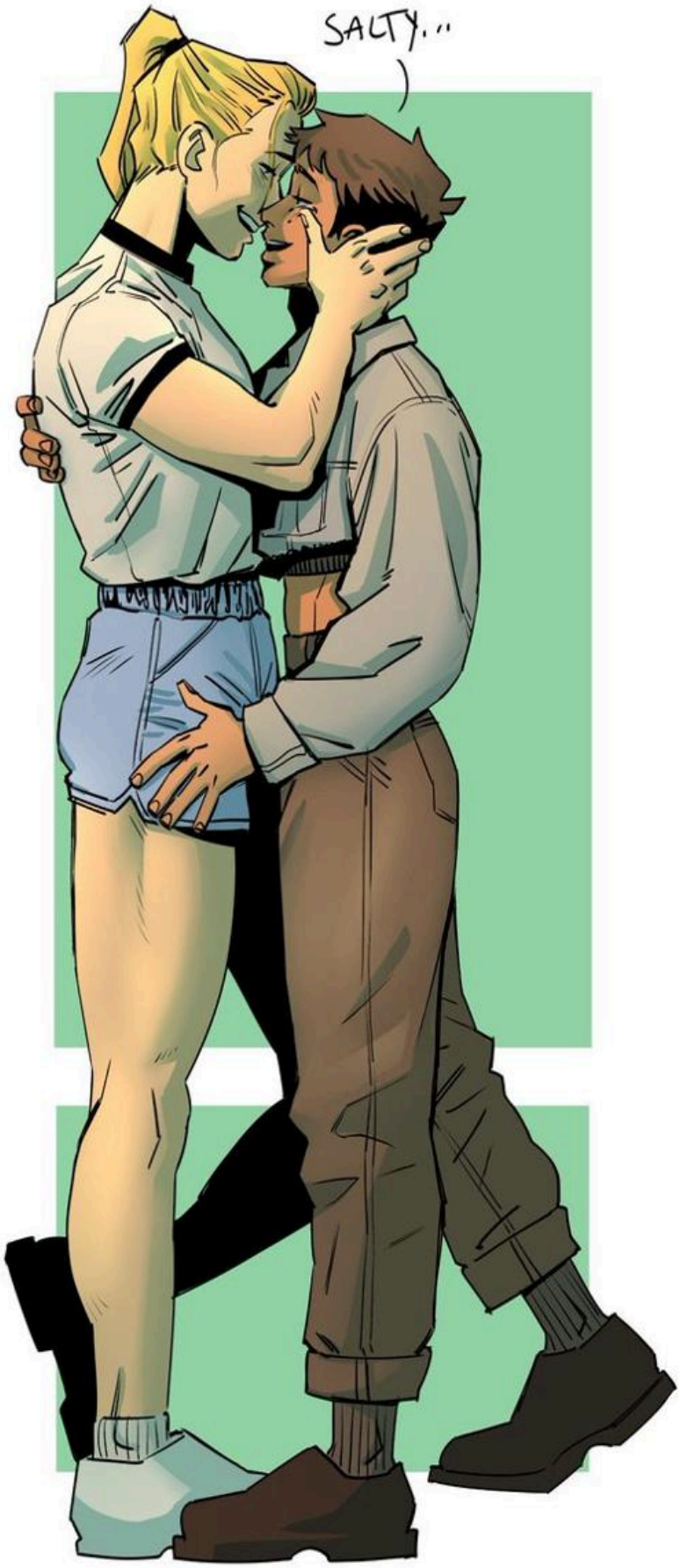
Catra is going to hate this room when she wakes up. The cheesy wallpaper, the tacky furniture and fake flowers. It was much too tidy. “Fake” she’d say. Adora gave her hand another squeeze.

“You played for me on our anniversary. Well, it wasn’t really you, but still, it was nice.”

She might be leaving town tomorrow, but she will be back. Angela promised to call her if anything changed. There would be no way she could leave if Beatrix still had any say, but she didn't anymore.

Things would change, they would, and for the better. Glimmer and Bow promised to come to talk to her until they left for school. Angella and Micha too, and they would keep coming. Might not need to, because she'd wake up soon. Hell, it wouldn't be that much of a surprise if she sat up right after Adora left, especially with Glimmer in the room, just to get a quip in.

"On our two year, I expect a new song. So get to work Cat. I won't let you get off easy." Adora brought Catra's hand up to her lips again, smiling into the little damp spot she felt there. "Salty."


SALTY..

Chapter End Notes

https://open.spotify.com/track/4YTFAawmOFyRjJdT6H95oE?si=4NcAVG85TRuNMmT3Iyan1g

The song I changed the lyrics too, to be more Catra in this story.

Incredible art done by https://twitter.com/lillylux1?s=21&t=xVZAMk0hxlgkFIZ6A4_cmw

Caress

Chapter Notes

> For those who don't like smut: This ch has pretty much everything but the spice. Like you can smell it's spicy, but you don't get to taste it.

She looked so real, playing with her ukulele in the back seat. Mindlessly strumming, the ting of the worn strings, the sound so unique to her. On those strings were fingerprints, blood, grease from french fries and smoke from campfires. The wood peeking from underneath the stickers were just like Catra's hair in this sunlight. Slight hues of gold shining through the dark chestnut waves, that ukulele was more Catra than any imitator could ever be.

Grungy decor to hide the scratches, obnoxious if you didn't mind, or even more so if you did. But if you appreciated it, held it the right way, knew what frets to press, and saw it as more than just an instrument, saw the worn strings for what they were, finger swirls of a girl who changes all she touches, the blood from hours of practice to find the right rhythm, the grease from uncleaned hands as she strummed between feeding you french fries, the smoke from campfires where she made her friends laugh, if you saw all these things, she made the most beautiful sounds.

"*Staring again Princess*?"

Yes, yes she was. She didn't want to take her eyes off of her. She didn't want to start the car. Adora would have to keep her eyes on the road.

"Not that I can blame you. I mean look at me, back here even. So many good times had on these seats." Catra looked down and pet the conveniently flat, even fabric fondly. The boxy design made it so they weren't the most comfortable to sit on, but laying down…

“I wonder what unwitting bad girl you’re going to turn good back here next?” Adora scoffed.

“As if, Cat. I’m not cheating on you, and turn good? You could’ve fooled me.”

“Oh, Adora. It would be a shame to let those impeccable forearms go to waste.” Catra was leaning forward, a familiar hunger in eyes, one that if life were as it was supposed to be, have Adora crawling back there with her. “And yes babe, you made me so soft. I swore I’d never write a love song, and look what happened.”

___

Four months, four months dating and years more with those thoughts poking thier erotic, blush inducing, head out at the most inconvenient of times. Adora was ready, god did she want it so bad. If sharing a bed on away games has been bad for Adora’s pure thoughts, those thoughts had gone nearly extinct now that they actually got to kiss and touch eachother. Adora closed her textbook. She hadn’t really even been absorbing the words anyway. Between being lost in her own thoughts and the growls and grunts coming from Catra she kept losing track of the words on the page. Just a slightly different pitch from the sweet sounds she made when she was worked up.

Catra had muted the tv so they could keep studying in peace without the sounds of Samus slaying her bounties. It worked for Glimmer but Adora kept twitching into smiles, furious blushes and barely restrained laughter because of her very animated girlfriend. Adora looked from her nest on the floor again to see Catra bouncing her leg anxiously, the tip of her tongue barely peeking out, face in deep concentration under furrowed brows. Saving the planet was serious business.

“Gaaaaaayyyy” Glimmer stage whispered, causing Catra to snort. Adora gave her friend a playful glare and shook her head. Catra glanced at her from over her shoulder, her leg still going a hundred miles an hour and then looked back at the screen. An alien on the screen exploded in a ring of pixels and she paused, returning Adora’s gaze with her signature cocky ass smirk this time.

“Staring again princess?” Catra tucked her lip between her fangs and winked

“I swear.” Glimmer groaned and shuffled her way out of the bean bag. “I thought this would get better but it’s only gotten worse.” Adora opened her mouth to argue but Catra beat her to it.

“Oh wow, you really had it bad didn’t you-” Glimmer smacked the side of her head. “Ow Sparkles. What the fuck?” God, even her glare was cute, it didn’t help that she was half hanging off the back of the chair, hair all mussed as she laid back to confront her assailant.

“Like you have room to talk.” Catra growled as their friend leaned over her, tousling her hair into even more of a mess. “Do I need to remind you that nearly everyone knew how utterly smitten you were with each other.” Glimmer laughed satisfiedly when Catra pushed her away.

Adora knew that she’d been obvious, that Glimmer and Bow had caught on almost immediately, just as about as immediately her crush formed for the grumpy, hoody wearing lump that glared at her from the hallway floor. Adora didn’t mean to knock her down! What a great first impression that was.

Bow and Glimmer were her first friends, not just in this new town, but in general. There were kids from the youth county teams she played soccer with that were sort of friends, but they usually didn’t have classes still in the summer, and after summer Adora didn’t really see them. When Hope had told her they were moving again, this time staying for the foreseeable future, she begged to

join a real school. It was the only thing that Adora refused to drop. To her luck, it was two people her age that dropped by a welcome basket as movers hauled the boxes in.

Hope had basically interrogated the two about the other neighborhood youth and their school. As Adora was quick to find out, Hope had been fooled by the pink and purple haired girl's warm smile. Glimmer had even convinced Hope to let them take Adora on a welcoming walk about.

These were good kids, and as long as Adora remained focused, they could spend time together.

So when the blush creeped up Adora's face when Catra glared up at her with a angry "What the fuck?!" They'd all spent enough time together to know that Adora was done for. She might have dropped Catra to the floor, but that toothy snarl was a one, two punch K.O. for Adora's heart.

"Hey Glim, I know you knew when I started crushing on Cat…"

"Hey, wait when was- ow FUCKING STOP GLIMM-." Catra was cut off again by the hand that smacked her being pressed over her mouth.

"Don't interrupt your girlfriend."

"So anyway Glim," Adora continued, nonplussed by the struggle both her girlfriend and best friend had found themselves in. "I was wondering-"

"YOU DID NOT JUST BITE ME!" Glimmer shook her hand out as Catra's gorgeous cackle blessed Adora's ears.

"Look who's interrupting now. Rude." Adora almost got up to stand between them, but a few hisses later Glimmer backed away and faced Adora expectantly. Adora looked over at Catra for confirmation. One two-toned eye roll later told Adora that their duel had come to a conclusion. She wasn't sure who won.

“So Glim, when did you know that Catra had feelings for me?” Catra groaned and the remainder of Glimmer's sour puss face receded into a grin.

“Sports.” Glimmer spouted smugly. “Catra Weaver’s sudden interest in sports. All that talk about hating jocks, and suddenly she starts showing up to games.” Catra sniffed loudly, making her displeasure at this topic known. “I knew for certain though when she joined the team.”

“I didn’t join the team because of Adora.” Catra mumbled, sinking down into her shirt.

“Auuu Cat! You joined the team because you liked me?”

“No, I did not like you.” The blush creeping up the visible remainder of Catra’s face told Adora otherwise.

“The flirting is at least better now in some ways. Adora is usually being cute, unlike your obnoxious ass.” Glimmer said as she walked around the room to pick up their empty tea cans. “Its the worst though when you two are eye fucking.” She bent down over Adora, pressing a finger against her hair poof as if to stick her point before taking Adora’s empty drink. “Don’t make us think about all nasty you two get into. The sexual tension, I swear to the gods. I bet if I weren’t here right now- not going to think about it.” Glimmer shook her head and stuck her tongue out at Adora, just in case her words fell wrong.

It had taken a while for Adora to learn that Glim often wasn’t actually upset, just teasing. The “fight” that her and Catra just had, when something like that happened in the past, used to send Adora into a panic. The way Glimmer said things with such conviction had always confused Adora. Catra too, at first anyway, until she learned to look for the tiny crinkles in the corner of her eyes that gave it away. Catra didn’t seem to have a problem understanding, she just often chose to play obtuse. Catra knew Glimmer longer than Adora had thought. The two of them had only become friends again about a year and half ago. It was

Adora that brought them back together. Adora had come choked with worry to Catra before practice one morning about a fight she had with Glimmer, only for Catra to tell her it probably wasn't a fight at all.

Glimmer was waiting for some sort of sarcastic response from her quip about their sex life but then her face fell to confusion when she saw that the two love birds were looking very pointedly anywhere but at one another, both red as birthday balloons. The realization washed over her slowly. "Oh.. you two.. haven't…" Slowly, she crept her way towards the stairwell. "My bad. I'm just gonna go get us uh more .. yeah tea."

Catra stared up at some very interesting paint on the ceiling while Adora bore a hole in the carpet. It seemed like Glimmer had won that round after all, accidentally knocking the wind out of Adora too. The clock, the buzz of the box tv, the sound of Catra's bouncing foot wasn't making Adora feel any less awkward.

Adora cleared her throat and pushed up off the floor. They should probably talk now, or else this was going to hang over them all night. With a deep breath she walked over and planted herself into Catra's lap, knocking the wind out of her. Catra groaned but Adora didn't move herself at all to help. She wiggled and squirmed until Adora was properly positioned so that she was actually sitting on her lap, instead of just sitting on her. Catra loved it when Adora nestled into her like this, but she also loved breathing and the girl was heavy.

"Well that was.." Catra raised a brow, still staring up at the ceiling in spite of the beautiful blonde seated on her.

"I mean…" Adora mumbled. She could feel her heart beating in her ears, thrumming loudly over her thoughts. They'd gotten heated before, a few suggestively placed limbs, kisses a little higher or lower on the stomach that would be considered more daring than sweet. Something always stopped them though, like worry of being walked in on, the battle marches of tiny forest

denizens, but more often than not it was just one of them freezing up, and returning hands and lips to more polite places.

Adora wanted to know though, wanted to feel Catra's hands hold her gently in places they haven't touched yet. She'd had more than one dream of Catra moaning beneath her, kissing her with wild abandon. Technically, that dream could come true, if she just talked about it? Be brave Adora. "I would um.. like to, soon." Catra shot up, straining to stay up without anything to support her back. Bean bags were really not convenient. Hard to sit up in if you laid down, hard to get out of. Adora snorted and wrapped her arm around her shoulders to support her.

She searched Adora's shy blue eyes, unable to close her mouth. "I mean.. Yeah me too." The flush had creeped all the way down Adora's neck at this point. Catra swallowed hard when Adora slowly leaned down toward her, her other hand finding its way to Catra's neck. They'd kissed at least a hundred of times by now. Surely the sparks behind her eyelids shouldn't still be happening.

This kiss felt more like a promise though, a tease of something more, a preview of a future maybe soon to come. They started falling backwards slowly once Adora's fingers found their way back to exploring the shape of her head under those short, dark curls. Catra gave up all hope of staying upright, moving her own arms to do the same. Long blonde strands surrounded her once the hair tie was tossed across the room. Without her elbows to keep her upright they were flat, the beads in the bag shifting under their combined weight. They didn't dare separate to stop it, giving into the slow slide down the basement floor.

This stupid chair was much to small for this. Catra didn't care when her shoulders pressed against the carpet. Adora was glued to her, not that she had much choice with the way Catra pulled her down. Gravity was doing its job and Catra was in heaven, future back pain be damned. She wondered what it would be like to have Adora's hips pinned against hers like this but with a lot less clothes on. The only sounds filling the basement were the hum of the cheap tv, the static sounds of the bean bag moving

under them and their heavy breaths when they parted briefly for cool air or when the kisses trailed away to neck, cheeks and ears. One of them should have heard the door opening.

“Jesus! That didn’t mean do it right now.” Glimmer sputtered, accentuating her point with a gag. Adora planted her hands on the ground and pushed herself up to look at their friend. It took every ounce of willpower Catra had to look away from the suddenly excellent view of her girlfriend's breasts. She’d much rather stare at those.

“Aw, Sparkles. Why do-” Catra suddenly had a hand pressed over her mouth again. It did more than silence her, but unfortunately now was not the time or place to explore that. She saw a twinkle in those deep blue eyes that she’d not experienced before.

“You wanna join us?” She finished for Catra with a fiendish grin. Catra let out a delighted squeak into her palm.

“I fucking love you.” It was muffled but she was pretty sure that Adora understood anyway.

Finally it was Glimmer's turn to be embarrassed. Slowly she set the cans down on the end table near the door. “I regret more and more each day that we helped this happen.”

Adora didn’t believe for a second that Catra didn’t come back here on purpose. Even in the night she recognized that tiny, crumbling shack they passed on their way out of town. When they first drove up here Adora would have been lying if she said she hadn’t thought of it as a possible location. As much as Catra talked about not caring where they were going, this was very intentional. No destinations my ass. The distant twinkle of shops of the town, no nearby lights glaring through the windows. It was just them, the

stars, and countless trees swaying in the cool breeze. They were all alone in Catra's old Lincoln Continental. She wasn't going to complain though, far from it. When Adora climbed out of her bedroom window she wondered if tonight it could happen. It might not but it could.

Adora sighed against her lips, her fingers playing at what should have been the edge of Catra's bra if she'd been wearing one. It's as far as she'd gotten, as far as she dared. Catra chuckled as she pulled away, leaning back against the seat. Adora opened her eyes slowly to see her girlfriend smirking at her.

"If I made you uncomfortable.." The last thing she wanted to do was push Catra into anything, she thought though, from how Catra was responding...

Catra rolled her eyes and pushed Adora's back against the seat, moving so she was straddling her. It was a perfect fit, there was just enough room above her to move without smacking her head on the roof of the car. It's not like they had many options back here. Maybe with some creativity, forethought and the untamable will power of an eighteen year old's libido they'd figure out something. Catra leaned down and kissed her. Her teeth captured an already swollen lip she gently pulled on it, causing Adora's breath to sharply hitch. Hopefully it also pulled her back out of her head. "Adora, no. You didn't make me uncomfortable." Catra said as she rubbed their noses together.

"I mean, really, babe." Catra whispered into her ear before grabbing Adora's hands that found themselves at rest comfortably on her hips. Adora blushed, she always did when Catra pulled out the pet names. There were so many different things Adora had stored away to call Catra. They were in their own corner of her mind, waiting, if the day ever came when she got to call her the top one on her list. Girlfriend, the word highlighted and written with big block letters, pinned to the filing cabinet of her imagination. She'd only crossed a few off her list so far but she already had some favorites.

“Really what, sweetheart?” Adora was glad that at least she wasn’t the only one beet red anymore. She hadn’t used that one much yet, she wanted to save it, to savor the response it got. Catra slowly lifted Adora’s hands and pressed them against her bare stomach. Catra guided her, her finger tips urging Adora’s hands upwards from over her shirt, Catra’s soft skin sending embers into her palms. Adora stopped, pressing lightly into her ribs. She could feel the skin of where she really wanted her hands brush against her knuckles.

“Really, Adora. What do you want?” Catra traced her nails gently, slowly, up the side of Adora’s arms, her thumbs riding the curves of her forearms, lingering in the pools at her elbow and the divots of her biceps on their way to her shoulders. “Tell me Adora.” Catra said with a hard swallow. She was doing her best to urge Adora into confidence with her own. Her voice was gravely, shaky. Adora could tell that for once Catra was just as nervous as she was.

She let her hands inch upward, feeling her way up, Catra’s shirt sliding up with her slow movement. Adora dipped her head down and pressed a forceful kiss high on her stomach. “I want you, Catra. I want to do this with you.”

Catra’s hands found themselves firmly on each side of Adora’s jaw and she pulled her into a bruising kiss that set them both on fire. It was finally happening. Catra was going to show Adora just how much she loved her, trusted her, in a way she’d never wanted to do with anyone else.

They learned that night to crack the windows. Adora learned what Catra sounded like. It wasn’t like all the video’s she’d secretly watched. There wasn’t any screaming. It was gentle gasps, whimpers, needy moans and quiet shuddered breath. It was feeling her heartbeat against her palm. In fact, it was probably the quietest Catra had ever been in her whole life. Noisey, yes, loud no. With every sigh from Catra, Adora was carried by the sound. Her lips whispered praises and devotion against her skin. Adora hadn’t told her that she’d loved her already, there would be no way she’d been able to hold it back then.

She learned a lot about herself that night too. Adora never doubted that Catra was attracted to her, not since that first kiss but it was the first time she felt truly beautiful. It it was the first time she like her body was more than just a machine built for performance. Silently, Catra's world wonder eyes roamed over her for what felt like an eternity ending with a heavy "Wow." When Catra touched her, she couldn't think about anything else. Always thinking, calculating, not that night, or any other night that came after with Catra pressed against her. Catra carved 'beautiful' with every touch on Adora's skin. She never wanted to forget the way Catra felt, inside her, against her. She didn't think forgetting could ever be something she'd have to worry about.

—

Adora rolled down the window a few inches for fresh air before looking up at the rear view mirror. She didn't see her back there. She turned in the driver seat to double check. Catra was still there after all. She was laying down, her shirt hiked up slightly, running her hand slowly down her stomach and smirking. Catra licked her lips and slid her fingers under the waist of her jeans.

"Shut up." Adora blurted out. Catra belted out in laughter. The car was well shaded by the giant oak that grew in her yard but her whole body felt feverish. She knew her face was as red as the day they'd fallen asleep in Scorpia's hammock. Catra, the weirdo, actually enjoyed peeling the dead skin off her shoulders for weeks. Her and Glimmer actually tried to see who could get the biggest piece. At least Bow was normal.

"Aw, what's wrong princess? You know you can't fool me. I always knew you were a big perv."

She sighed and let her head roll back against the headrest. Catra sat back up, perched in the middle, elbows on her knees, head in

her hands. Adora wanted so badly to kiss her again, for real. To feel that pulse beneath her lips, to feel it rise. To see those spikes on the screen change for once. At first that steady rhythm was a comfort.

"I always imagined our first time would be in like.. I don't know. A bed." Adora fiddled with the broken radio knob. The way Catra made her squirm and grope at things desperately so often in the back seat, it was a wonder she'd never broken anything back there. There was a time or two she considered yanking out the seat belt fasteners. They both got a lot of awkward bruises from the plastic digging into their sides, but that never stopped them.. "I'd light candles. " Catra giggled from the back seat and Adora flashed her a smile. "Or maybe we'd just be hanging out, you playing your ukulele. You'd play me something sweet and just .." She sighed again. "I don't know. I don't think we ever got to even do..*that* in a bed."

"You know what.. I think you're right." Catra grabbed the edges of the front seats and leaned forward. She reached a hand out and pressed it against her shoulder. Adora closed her eyes and laid her hand over hers. She could feel it this time. Adora traced the ridges of the back of her hand. It was the one thing she could still do for Catra, hold her hand at the edge of the hospital bed. Closing Catra's fingers around her own. That's probably why she could still feel this recreation sometimes, with her hands anyway. "Could you imagine. One of our mom's walking in or hearing us." That made Adora sit back up, giving wide eyes to her girlfriend. No, no she could not.

"Hope would've lost her shit. I mean, because it was you." Adora mumbled. Catra tutted in agreement. "And then your mom..." That would have been a nightmare. Probably would have chased them out with one of the many crosses or wine bottles around the house.

"It was a pain in the ass for sure but I kinda liked it." She said with a wink. Adora furrowed her brows, not quite sure what direction Cat was going with that statement. "Being the bad girl,

the dirty little secret of the golden child.” It was Adora’s turn to roll her eyes.

“You weren't a secret, at least to our friends.” Adora sent her a soft smile. It was definitely something Catra would say but, she hoped that she really didn’t feel that way. Adora would have screamed it from the mountain tops, hijacked the school’s pa system, to announce to the world how much she loved her girlfriend. Tell the world how beautiful, smart and wonderful she was. A one woman comedy show, singing voice of an angel, a laugh that made the clearest bell pale in comparison.

Catra’s eyes softened and she reached to brush a tear off of Adora’s cheek, lips twisting into a frown when it rolled right past, hovering at the edge of Adora’s chin.

She would give anything to see Catra aura’d by the cosmic rays that traveled hundreds of thousands of miles to cast shadows in the back seat of Catra’s car. To turn and see golden light reflected off her short, curly, dark brown hair instead of the sickly fluorescent lights.

“Hey” Catra whispered as she cupped her chin. She didn’t have to follow but she did. Catra did this whenever the anxiety got too much, literally pulling her out of it, pressing their foreheads together, counting their breaths. Adora took a deep breath now, those sky and amber eyes pressed close to hers. “Those are fun memories okay? I’m the one who cries after sex.” Adora laughed, she couldn’t help it. “Makin’ me feel all, special n’ shit.”

Cross

Chapter Notes

> Remembering all the 90's and 2000's slang/sayings and not using modern ones is hard sometimes

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora scrolled down the guide, hitting the bottom and waiting for the new information to pop up on the screen before reading them off.

"HGTV? We could make fun of the people who paint over brick. There's also a vampire movie marathon, for some reason? Probably because of that Twilight movie coming out next year. I know you liked Underworld and Blade, but those are both in a few hours. Let's see…" Adora continued to scroll, commenting here and there when something interesting or unusual popped up.

Eventually she settled on the cartoons, something she could drown out, but with interesting noises to maybe rouse and stimulate that dwelling curiosity. Adora read quite a few articles where when the patient woke up, they could remember everything they heard. Sometimes Adora put on something familiar, but if Catra could hear, (Adora just knew she could, Glasgow coma scale be dammed) she must get bored. Let her guess a little.

Adora moved the chair so she was sitting as close to the head of the bed as she could. She wedged her pillow in the corner of her chair and kicked her feet up on the edge of Catra's bed. Catra sure had a knack for getting Adora to do what Bow and Glimmer failed at time and time again, relax. This tactic was a bit extreme though.

She preferred the other ways Catra poked holes in her routine. Adora turned her head, pushing the pillow down just enough so she could see the shallow rise and fall of Catra's chest.

Occasionally it rose higher, a deeper inhale. Look at her, still breathing on her own.

" *Hey, Cat.* " Adora reached out and gave her shoulder a gentle tap. " *Scoot over, you bed hog.* " She fought to keep the smile on her lips. She wished she could crawl up there with her. She needed it, the comfort, the courage. Those arms wrapped around like a seatbelt did more than hold her down, they kept her safe from herself.

If things were normal, if things were right, then they'd both be packing up the car. Hell, they probably would've left right after graduation. Catra would get one or two more paychecks in, the money that Adora had put to paying for Catra's car would be parsed out for each state they planned on visiting, and they would just… drive. Adora wouldn't have to say goodbye. Adora wouldn't be driving all those miles alone tomorrow.

They could be anywhere right now, throwing stones into the ocean, racing against the sun to finish their ice cream, sand between their toes. They could be sipping from water skins, astride the slowest donkey that the website said was named Swift, taking in all the colors of the Grand Canyon.

If Adora had left even sooner, taken that sudden turn Catra asked of her, none of this ever would've happened, they could be anywhere right now.

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Catra reached lazily to the popcorn bowl Glimmer had just set on the coffee table.

"No." Glimmer glared at her, tapping her foot angrily against the carpet. "You always take up the big couch." Catra popped a few pieces into her mouth, crunching loudly. She lifted her hands

above her head as she chewed, pushing her legs out, back arching as she stretched to cover as many seat cushions as possible. Glimmer continued to glare, Catra feigned a yawn.

“Eat my shorts, Glitter.”

“Catra, I swear to everything that’s holy I’m going to-” There was a knock on the front door before it opened with a trail of giddy teenagers bouncing in.

Bow and Adora both had armfuls of two liters, Scorpia and Perfuma were loaded with chips and cookies and Entrapta carried a mountain of tiny treats. The whole gang was present which meant the annual horror movie madness could commence.

“Baby?” Catra called out from her couch kingdom. Adora answered with a distinct Adora hum, pleased by the pet name. “Would you mind getting my drink too when you grab yours?”

“Dr Pepper?”

“Yeah! Thank you. If I get up, we lose our seat to the evil spot stealing Shimmer.”

“You act like you live here.” Glimmer towered over Catra, who resumed loudly munching away at the popcorn.

Adora left the Glitra bickering session and tutted away in the kitchen, pulling down bowls and glasses from cabinets that she’d come to know just as much as her own. She was just about to get the ice when Perfuma tapped her shoulder.

“I’ll get it Adora.” Scorpia waved her off, taking the ice tray right out of her hands. Scorpia tried to make it seem friendly, but her voice was strained and she took the tray a little too quickly. Before she knew it, Perfuma had her arm and was dragging her across the Moons’ kitchen. Bow gave Adora a furtive smile, this wasn’t going to be a talk Adora wanted to have apparently.

As soon as they were well out of earshot of the living room Perfuma turned to face her, hands on Adora's arms to keep her in place.

"Did you tell her yet?"

Adora let out a heavy sigh.

"The longer you wait, the worse it's going to be Adora." For as gently as Perfuma said it, those words dumped rocks straight to her stomach.

"Why can't it wait until she hears back too? She isn't playing for them, but she applied, only a few more months and, yeah she might be mad I didn't tell her right away but at least then we'll both *know* we're going to Bright." It was hard enough just trying to keep her mouth shut, and play cool around Catra, she didn't need their friends nagging her about it. College was a touchy subject in general around both of them. Hope had so much she expected from Adora, while Cat spent her whole life being told she'd never even graduate high school. Catra had been antsy at every game that had college scouts, which was a lot of them thanks to Adora's goal record. The fact that Catra talked about going to Bright at all was a miracle.

"What if she doesn't? We all know she'll get in, but there's still a chance. You don't want to drop both of those on her at the same time. She won't take it well."

"I don't want her to worry about it yet! She's actually turning her work in instead of lying that she didn't do it. And her SAT scores! She's getting in, Fuma. This is the first time in years she's talked about actually going to college, I'm not going to give her reason to slide again."

"You have to tell her-"

"Perfuma, please. Come February, hell, maybe January this will all be taken care of when she gets her offer letter. It's just a few months."

"No, trust me. It'll be so much worse if this doesn't work out for her. We don't know for certain. I know you don't want to hurt her, but sometimes when you think you're protecting someone- remember when you waited until last minute to tell her that you were going to be gone all of that summer?"

That had been bad, really bad. Hope had been talking for months about taking Adora across the country for a specialty soccer camp, summer training with retired MLS players. Adora begged in the privacy of her room for it not to happen, left little notes in places Hope might find about how she didn't want to go. Adora had told her too, but Hope pretended not to hear. She wanted a normal summer, to hang out with her friends, go camping with Cat, like they talked about.

Adora had finally gotten around to telling Catra about it the last week of school, only for it not to matter at all. Adora came home on the last day of school to see her leave date crossed off the calendar. It took a thousand and one apologies for Catra to talk to her again, but this was different. That was two years ago though, and they were dating now, Adora had to look out for her, even if that meant remaining silent for a while.

"I don't know how that doesn't prove my point?" Adora stopped trying to hide her annoyance, letting it slip out with ease. "It didn't matter, and Cat went off and found a second job that she ended up having to juggle all summer."

"If you had told her sooner, Adora, she probably wouldn't have done that."

"If I hadn't told her at all-"

"You know," Scorpia said from behind Adora, startling her out of her glare. "For two people who talk so highly of one another, you sure don't *talk* to each other." Adora turned to face her, blinking in confusion at the unusual stony expression on the softie's face.

"Did she say something to you?"

“Adora-” Perfuma rose her hand to her forehead, massaging just above her temples. The queen of Zen had run out of mantras to give. “Catra has asked nearly everyone she can if recruiters have contacted them yet. We know it’s not for her, she made it clear that she wasn’t looking to play in college.”

Glimmer let out an incoherent yell with Catra’s cackling following soon after, turning everyone’s attention towards the living room. Adora took the opportunity to side step out from in between the couple hell bent on making that laughter die out. She picked up her and Catra’s glasses and walked out before they could get another word in.

“Took you long enough, having the party without me?” Catra said playfully, still firmly strewn across the prime movie watching couch.

“Scoot over, you bed hog.” Adora gave a half hearted laugh. She tried to push down the anxiety those beautiful eyes were unwittingly causing her. It was one thing to keep something to yourself for a while, but after being called out, it felt like she’d been lying, and that mischievous gaze clawed guilt right through her.

“Oh I’m sorry, I did say I was saving this for us didn’t I? I misspoke, this spots’ jus’ for lil ole me.” An eager flush poured into Catra’s cheeks over her toothy, lopsided grin.

“Can we fast forward the mating ritual and get to the gore please?” Entrapta said from the top of the bookshelf, startling everyone. She looked like a strange gargoyle with her homemade 3D goggle mask on. Adora would’ve probably laughed if she didn’t have other things on her mind. None of the movies boasted 3D on the rental cases.

One of Catra’s arms was firmly around Adora’s waist, the other doubled as both a pillow and a grounding pressure across her chest. As chainsaws roared and blood curdling screams pierced the air, all Adora could process in the room was how hard her

heart was pounding. Guilt wasn't an unfamiliar bedfellow for her. Missed chances on the soccer field, that one B on her report card, but none of them filled her so completely with this mind consuming, body tingling guilt… and fear.

Every puff of warm breath against her ear, every slight shuffle behind her, every reassuring brush of Catra's thumb on her shoulder made the numbness worse. Catra had asked everyone about recruitment except her. Adora's offer letter was hidden under a pile of papers in her desk drawer, specifically so Catra wouldn't accidentally find it. Cat assumed Adora wasn't going to tell her, that she'd hide it, and she was right. What kind of good girlfriend does that?

"That actually scare you?" Catra whispered into her ear. The credits were rolling on the tv and a table lamp flicked on. Adora glanced around the room as people got up to stretch. The ritual on horror night involves fifteen minute interludes for bathroom and breather breaks. As for breather, both Bow and Scorpia looked like they needed it after all that blood. Perfuma and Glimmer practically dragged each other to the movie pile, both their eyes hungry for violence.

After a thump from Entrapta sliding off the bookshelf and a "Dibs on the small bathroom." they were alone temporarily. Adora finally shook her head no to Catra's question. She couldn't hold this any longer. The hour and half or so of the movie felt like a lifetime. She needed to tell her, now, or shrivel up and die.

Adora shifted awkwardly until she faced Catra, so close their noses pressed together. Catra's eyes grew heavy with concern, only closing to press a gentle kiss on Adora's unresponsive lips.

"I have to tell you something."

Catra inhaled sharply, fingers curling into Adora's side.

"Did…did I do..? Whatever it is Dor-" Adora closed the fraction of distance between them with her lips.

“No Cat. It’s not…” Adora let out another shaky breath. “I’m sorry I didn’t tell you sooner.” Adora said it so quiet, that the sound of Catra’s breathing was louder than her words. “I got a call, two weeks ago. Bright wants me to play for them.”

It took a moment for Catra to catch up, but when she did, there was a flash of excitement. The excitement didn’t last long enough to back up the “That’s great, Dor.” that fell from her lips. Catra kissed her again, both of them stiff this time, like an obligatory hug goodbye your mother told you to give a relative that you’d just met for the first time.

“Cat-”

“I said that’s great, Dor.”

If she thought the first movie was long, the second one was even longer. She could feel Catra silently spiraling behind her. Adora glared at the tv only to avoid glaring at Perfuma. The couch was crowded, uncomfortable. She’d have left if it wouldn’t just be added to the imaginary pile Catra was currently compiling that she was going to be abandoned, alone in the world once again.

It wasn’t just because she didn’t want to hurt Catra, she also didn’t want to tell her yet for selfish reasons. Adora knew that now, but knowing she was right to not tell her didn’t make her feel any better. She didn’t want to deal with this again. How was she supposed to apologize for something that wasn’t going to happen? Hadn’t everything she’d done up till now proven that she was Catra’s, that she wasn’t going to leave her, and nothing was going to change that?

When the credits rolled again they both sat up. Catra silently stood up and crossed the room, grabbing her keys from an end table, all the while looking like a beat dog. Adora ground her teeth, finally giving Perfuma that blazing look she’d been shoveling coals into for the last hour. She didn't have time to chew out Perfuma though because the front door was opening behind her, and she wasn’t about to let it close.

Neither of them said a word as they got in the car, the crunching of snow beneath Adora's feet was the only reason Catra knew she was there, not even turning around to look at her. Not a peep left either of them as Catra drove. Adora was trying not to be angry, but there was a pity party of one happening in the driver's seat and Adora was going to have to clean up after the unnecessary wallowing. She knew Catra was just scared, worried, all that would be okay if she'd actually just say that instead of cooking up some doomsday scenario.

Catra parked the car the usual block away from Adora's house. Adora crossed her arms and stared at Catra as she fiddled with the keys in her hand. She wasn't about to leave, not until Catra talked to her. When Catra finally looked back at her, Adora found an anxious excitement there.

"Run away with me. Let's do it, tonight. We're both adults, they can't stop us."

"Cat-"

"You don't even want to go to college anyway. How many times have you said you weren't even sure you wanted to go for? Come on Dor, I'll help you get stuff down from your window. Leave this hell hole with me." Catra's voice was rough, bleeding with the tears she was holding back.

"Catra, no. We haven't even graduated yet! What would we do? How would we pay for food?! For gas?!"

"I'll figure it out okay. That's for future us to worry about. Please Adora, we could go anywhere, do anything. You're miserable at home, so am I! We could be free. Just leave with me! It'll be fine, I promise, as long as we look out for each other, as long as we're together, it'll be fine. Let's do this."

"I love you so much Cat, but we can't just leave like this. Tonight? Not even going to wait to see if you get in? Is that how little you

think of yourself? You're going to get in, okay? We'll both go to BU, and if not, I'm not just going to abandon you."

"Why would they want me, Adora?!" Catra was shaking now, tears finally starting to betray their master. She brought her hand up and hurriedly wiped them away before returning to her tight grip on the steering wheel. "I'm worthless. All I do is cause problems for everyone. They only put up with me. I don't matter, Adora. Nobody gives a -"

"Seriously Cat! You matter to me! You matter to our friends." Adora grabbed her chin, making sure she didn't look away, making sure she saw Adora say the words. "You matter to me, Cat. And what do you mean worthless? You're one of the hardest working, smartest, sweetest, cockiest people I'm ever going to meet. Cockiest! Worthless? Those aren't your words, those are your mother's. You've never listened to her a day in your life. Are you really going to start now?"

Catra bit the inside of her cheeks, futilely trying to stop her panicked tears. "Get out."

"Catra…"

Catra pressed her forehead to the wheel, trying to hide her face. "Get out, Adora. You don't get it. Get out, go be Hope's little perfect pet. Get out."

Adora did just that, half tempted to slam the door shut behind her but she didn't. Catra could fret over nothing if she wanted to, but that didn't mean that Adora had to take her frustration out on Catra like how Cat was doing to her.

Adora didn't remember falling asleep, but the ringing of her phone jolted her awake. It should've been on silent. She raced off of her bed and dug the phone from last night's pair of jeans, hopefully getting to it before Hope heard. The only cell phone that Hope knew about was handed over or left in the key bowl after 8.

“Hello?” Adora answered breathlessly and only half aware from being pulled so abruptly out of sleep.

“ *I’m so sorry. I’m so so sorry. You didn’t deserve that , I love you so much, I’m just scared. I didn’t mean to take it out on you. Please Dor, I’m so fucking sorry.”* She sounded rough, like she’d been up all night.

Adora took a deep breath, the worry that she went to bed with, the worry that Catra would run off anyway, drained from her. She also felt bad, she shouldn’t have told her around all their friends. Adora didn’t even give her the space to feel like she could deal with it.

“I know Cat, it’s okay. Let me see if Hope is home still, then you come pick me up? Or I can meet you somewhere?”

There was a big sigh of relief on the other side of the phone. “ *Okay.”*

——

She was careful to not put too much pressure on her shoulder. As much as she wanted to bury her face into Catra’s warm skin, she didn’t want to accidentally hurt her. Leaning so far forward on the chair, half holding her head up to keep the full weight off of Catra, was uncomfortable, but she just wanted to hold her again, hear the internal quakes of her still working body. Crooking her arm to not jostle IV, Adora took Catra’s hand in hers again, stroking the top of it.

“If you hadn’t been there, you were there because of me. I should have said yes - Just say the word Catra. I go where you go.” She couldn’t stop the spasms in her chest. Maybe it would be better if Catra couldn’t hear a thing.

“I’m serious Cat.” Adora buried her face into the hospital gown, breathing in the scent of her through the layer of cheap laundry

detergent. The sobs broke through, muffled against Catra's shoulder. "You were right. I don't want to go- I just- just wake up. Tell me, ask me again. We'll go, get out, go anywhere." Tomorrow she'd have Catra's car. Tomorrow she'd drive, drive so far away from here, just like Cat wanted, but without her, and for what? "I'm not leaving you, I'm never leaving you behind."

"Please, you promised. Please." It could have been five minutes or fifteen, shouting, whispering, whimpering those same words over and over into Catra's skin, as if she said it enough it would snap her out of it. It wouldn't be the first time Adora tried.

A knock on the door jolted her upright, she barely had time to rub the burn from her cheeks before the door opened. "Hey kid." Dr. Netossa Aura, the hospital administrator, spoke softly. Right behind her, her wife and the hospital's social worker, Spinneralla held a few paper bags in her hand.

"I can't leave yet, please this is my last day. I have to drive to the university tom-"

"You don't need to leave yet Adora." Netossa opened the door the rest of the way and gestured at the carry out in her wife's hands. "Could we join you for a bit? We brought food. If you want to, you could also help with Catra's exercises? Get those limbs moving a bit?" She'd been allowed the room often now when the nurses moved Catra around to prevent bed sores, they didn't always have the heart to ask her to leave. At first it was hard to watch, but it brought some comfort knowing they were taking care of her properly.

Adora turned back to the resting form on the bed, the one who promised that she'd look out for Adora. Catra still was, even if she didn't know it. Adora would look out for her too. She would take care of her.

"Okay."

Chapter End Notes

Kudos comments and sharing are greatly appreciated. We are getting places! I have most if the last ch I need to write finished. It’s gonna end up nearly a 10k ch so forgive me if it takes a day or two more when that ch cones up for posting. I’ve had a busy week

Curse

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The gentle playing in the back seat ceased. Adora turned in her seat, the little creases around Catra's eyes told her that she was up to no good. She was going to be adorably wrinkly there when she gets old. Catra took a deep breath, paused and strummed wildly against the strings. The chords were chaos, violent sounds without rhythm. A strangled "AAAAAAHHH" poured out of her mouth.

"What are you doing?"

"Playing our break up song." Catra said with a smirk. Nothing could put out her bullishness, not even Adora.

"What? We haven't broken up Catra. I'm not breaking up with you. If you want to then wake the hell up and tell me yourself."

"You're leaving Princess, what else would you call this?"

"Catra, get it through that thick skull of yours, I'm not *leaving* you."

"Skull's not thick enough apparently!"

"Catra-" Adora snapped at her but Catra's smile grew more amused.

"You missed your chance though, should've gotten it in there before they stapled it back together."

"Catra sto-"

"I'm not Beetlejuice you know. Saying my name three times isn't going to make me go away." Adora slumped back in her seat. She

loved her mouthy girlfriend so much, too much. “Oh come on. I’m bored okay. We’ve been sitting here for hours. Let’s play a game, theoretical. The top ten things that would break us up.”

Adora shook her head. “No, you’re going to find some way to turn this against me. I can feel it.” She swallowed hard as Cat opened her mouth, bracing herself for whatever was about to happen.

“Number 10, you realize that I’m just into you for your body.” Adora groaned, this was not going to end well. “I mean those muscles.. Mmmm damn.” Catra wagles her brows, eyes tracing up Adora’s bare arm to one of her favorite places to playfully bite her, that big bulging bicep.

Catra continued staring at her, but Adora kept her mouth shut. Catra’s smile quickly turned upside down, her lips beginning to tremble, a hint of a tear forming around her eyes.

“Number 9.” Adora said with a sigh. “I meet someone just as hot as you are but isn’t such a jerk.”

“Fat chance- and you love that about me.” She sniffed loudly to emphasize her dismissal.

“ *Theoretical,* remember.” Adora bit back mockingly.

“Theoretical, not *fantasy* , Number 8 Hope catches me between your legs and tosses me out the window, your window’s get replaced with bars and you can’t sneak out to see me anymore and I die of heartbreak because I think you just gave up.” Catra clutched at her chest, now feigning a longing and forlorn look up Adora’s bedroom window.

“Pfft. I’d just jump out the window after you and I'd probably ask you then, to actually run away together. That one shouldn’t be on the list at all.” She would, Adora would just jump down after her. The tree would be easier to climb down but if it were the other window she wouldn’t hesitate to jump.

“Fine, skip number 8 then.” By the devilish glint in those eyes, Adora knew she had something big planned, but she wasn’t going to be out done. She needed to get more silly, hopefully distract Catra.

“Number 7, I insist on a house full of dogs and we live on a farm with horses.” Adora beamed satisfied at the life prospect she knew Catra would hate. “In the middle of nowhere, but only surrounded by other good ole country folk where they only listen to Toby Keith and Garth Brooks.”

“But the thing that makes me finally snap is when you name one of our animals “Swiftwind” all because an 8 year old you thought it was funny.” Catra added, unaffected by her answer.

“I’d settle for Swifty! You want to name our first cat Melog, so don’t go there.”

“I'm dyslexic and it made The Hobbit more interesting.” Adora still didn’t believe that was the reason, but she let it slide.

“Number 6. You call me cute one to many times.”

“But you are cute.”

“No I'm not. I’ll only accept, sexy, hot, stud, uh lets see, best you ever had.” Adora bit back a laugh, she wasn’t about to let Catra win this game. “Number 5-”

“Hey! It’s my turn!” Catra ignored her, drowning out the complaint with a strum.

“Number 5. “You finally leave me to go off and be a ‘skolar’. Almost happened, don’t deny it.”

“Did not, and would never happen, Cat. 4,” Even though it still kind of felt like that’s what she was about to do today, she couldn’t dwell and let Catra steal another turn. “You run off and form a criminal organization. Solely dedicated to harassing

Glimmer, and probably me too. I wouldn't be able to just stand by, watching you march mayhem on our friends."

"Speaking of!" Catra exclaimed loudly. "Reason number 3 for our theoretical break up: Sparkles." She waited for Adora to respond but nothing came. "Enough said I guess." They quickly moved past that one because it hit a little too close to home. Glimmer might be partially responsible for getting them together but she'd also nearly foiled Adora and Catra's friendship at the beginning.

"Number 2" Adora whispers seductively. She really needed to pull out a big one if Catra had number 1. It was time to dig in deep into Catra's dirty secrets. "You're at the coffee shop and waiting for your order, at first not recognizing the beauty next to you. Pink reaches for what she thinks is her coffee, but it's yours and your fingers brush."

" 'Catra' she says with a gasp, reading my name on the cup. 'What a beautiful name.' " Catra looked up wistfully, imagining the musician that blessed her ears and heart. Pink was the only celebrity on Catra's 'trapped in an elevator' list. Shit, why didn't Adora use an elevator for this scene.

"You chat the day away, forgetting about lil old me with that gorgeous voice and vivacious figure before you. Next thing I know, you're off being a groupie, having the time of your life, never to think of me again."

Catra was still looking up dreamily at the fuzzy fabric above them, thoroughly enjoying fantasy Adora wove for her. "Oh that's a good one." Catra said finally, snapping out of it and grinning maniacally. "The most probable except for Number 1!"

Catra took a long inhale through her nose, strummed a few times and belted. "NUMBER ONE, THE NUMBER ONE REASON WE SPLIT UP, NUMBER ONE IS. ONE IS… drumroll please Adora." Catra thudded her fist on the roof of the car between every yell. Adora rolled her eyes as Catra stared at her, waiting for the requested theatrics. With a sigh Adora tapped her fingers against the

steering wheel if only so the drama queen would finally finish this stupid game. Catra took another deep breath and fell down dramatically in the back seat. “CATRA GETS HIT BY A CAR ON HER WAY BACK FROM THE LIBRARY AND SMACKS HER HEAD OPEN ON THE PAVEMENT! If only I hadn’t cracked open a book.”

Adora froze, her hands gripping the steering wheel like she was about to rip it off. A forgien noise left her. She couldn’t believe the sound that was coming out of her mouth. Catra sat up in the back seat with an arched brow. Adora was laughing, uncontrollably howling. If she didn’t think she was mad before, with her comatose girlfriend sitting the back seat playing for her, she sure as fuck knew it now.

“ *What’s so funny?”* Catra asked bluntly. Adora took in a few deep breaths, trying to regain some control of herself, what little she had left. Adora shook her head and smiled at the illusion.

“You are such an asshole!”

——

“ *Are you still sleeping?”* She wasn’t, but she was lounging.

“Well I answered the phone didn’t I dummy?” Catra smiled against the speaker at the huff Adora gave in return. She pushed back the curtain, squinting at the gleaming blanket of fresh snow their sleepy town had woken up too. “How do you want to spend what’s probably our last snow day?”

“ *What do you mean, last snow day?”*

“Well it’s not gonna snow much at BU, too far south. So, last snow day, what do you wanna do?”

“ *Well, what do you wanna do?”*

“What I wanna do is *tonight* , since your mom’s return flight got delayed.” Catra paused to let the blush she knew Adora was forming crawl up to her ears. “You pick what we do *today* .” There

was silence, but she knew it was just Adora contemplating. When they first met, she'd just say study or some sort of soccer drill, those were her go to's. It took practice, picking something that wasn't just aimed at improving Adora's skill set.

"Wanna see if the gang wants to play some board games?" Another chance to wipe the floor with Glimmer? That sounded fantastic.

"Hells yeah, babe. Sparkles place?" As much as Catra loved giving Glimmer a hard time, she loved her, and her corny family. No matter the time of day or night, Catra knew she could just go there. They even made her a key last year. Micah and Angella had tried to get Catra to move in with them multiple times, but she just couldn't do it. Home was bad, but she could handle it, and soon she wouldn't have to handle it anymore. The only offer from them that she did accept, was that she could stay there over future semester breaks. A true clean break from her mom, now that she finally knew where she was going after graduation.

" *Yup! I'll call them, see what time works but I'm guessing 2? You can come early if you want…"*

Catra tisked into the phone. "What, you think I like you or something?" She peered out the window again, eyeing the snow covered street. "Hmm, maybe not. The plow hasn't made it up this way yet. I'm gonna walk. I'll text you when I leave. I need to shower and get bundled up. Oh! I'm stopping by the library, my books came in yesterday. Do you want me to grab you anything from the mart across the street?"

Adora tried unsuccessfully to stifle her laugh. Catra's heart did little flip flops at her doofus of a girlfriend's chortle. That melody always had that effect on Catra. It had from the first nervous laugh when Adora helped her up after knocking her down in the hallway. Now she'd get to continue to hear it in person for the next four years, if they rented a place the next summer. This year though was set in stone at least. How could they say no to a scouted striker as highly rated as Adora? Maybe it wasn't smart to

request a dorm together but, a little distraction was worth hearing that laugh every day.

"What's so funny?" She growled into the receiver, attempting to sound annoyed just about as much as Adora had tried not to laugh.

" *Oh I don't know, Cat. The fact that you barely studied all of high school and now your PRE studying for college. It's cute, to see you so excited."*

"It's not cute, and it's not my fault our classes were boring. I didn't need to study for that shit anyway. I looked up some of the reading for the classes I'm thinking about taking. There's whole websites that post coursework history for specific schools, isn't that wild? The more prepared I am, the more free time I'll have, you know. Not to mention this stuff is actually interesting."

" *Tell me something interesting then, Catra. What has gotten my wonderful girlfriend to start using the library?"* Catra eyed the snowfall outside, the large fluffy flakes tumbling from the sky. The world around them would excite Adora too, if she just knew how to think about it differently. Catra had started to. It might have only been a few weeks since she'd gotten her letter, but the world felt less like a ride she was jousted onto already. She could learn it's secrets, change it, and not just *exist* on it.

"Look out the window." Catra waited for the footsteps to cease, hearing her cue at the clattering of blinds. Adora must be in her kitchen, Catra had almost gotten caught sneaking out because of those noisy ass things barricading the sliding glass door. "Okay, you see those big fluffy flakes? How softly they're falling." Adora responded with her rapt attention call of 'uh-huh'.

"Can you feel the way they'd caress your skin, melting at the contact? Giving you goosebumps as they trickled down the curves of your body." Catra almost laughed at the huff she received. "Featherlight kisses on your face, your neck, your *breasts.* "

" *Okay Professor, the snow is horny this morning."* Catra broke, cackling. *"You gonna tell me something that I don't know or am I going to have to lodge a complaint?"*

"Well Princess, if it weren't for all that air filling up the *empty* spaces. That snow would be like razorblades falling from the sky. It would slice us to bits."

Catra waited, she knew Adora was actually looking now, observing so carefully the way the crystallized water was rocking against nothing as it drifted down. *"Okay, that is really fucking cool."* Catra did a fist pump in her bed. She got a "fuck" out of Adora and it wasn't even noon yet, new record. By the end of their first semester, Grey was going to be cursing like a sailor.

"Alright, sweary, I'm gonna hop in the shower now. Might be a long one, *thinking about you and all. "*

"You're ridiculous." Catra slid off of her warm, cozy bed. Braving cold was worth it, if she got to spend the day with her dummy. *"I love you. "*

"Love you too. See you soon." Catra hung up the phone, setting it on her nightstand right on top of the bright blue and gold beanie Adora had gotten her for that silly party that she and their friends had thrown for Catra. Adora must have ordered it a while ago, because the party happened just two days after she got her letter from Bright University.

When Catra got back to her phone, about ready to pull on that ridiculous (and warm) beanie, she found a text waiting for her that made her groan. If only she'd gotten it before she'd finished dressing. At least she didn't already have her marshmallow level of puffy coat on yet.

' *Send me something to think about in the shower too…? ;)'*

Well, she wasn't about to get naked again. She slipped the hat into her pocket and stood in front of the mirror, doing her best to fit as much of herself as possible in the shot. Why did they always

put the camera in the back? Maybe with some of her reimbursement she could get one of those smartphones, it would be much easier to send Adora tantalizing photos without trying to guess the angle on every single selfie. Catra swept back her leather jacket, tucking the thumb of her free hand into her jeans. Who was she kidding, she always looked good, especially in red and black. She picked the shirt specifically to piss Glimmer off though. If Mr. and Mrs. Moon were home, they'd go off on another rant about that time they managed to be in the front row for Queen's last America tour. Just how glorious a view of Freddie's bulge they must have had.

Catra looked over the photo before sending it. Her mirror was due for a wipe down but it would have to tide her princess over. ' *Sorry babe, already dressed, but think about how you can strip these off me later. Have fun ;) I'm omw. See you soon.* '

She slipped the embarrassingly dorky hat on, with its bright gold horses and giant BU letters streaming across it. It was something that she normally wouldn't be caught dead wearing, but Adora got it for her, and yeah, maybe she was proud of herself.

—

"Why are you being so antsy?" Glimmer asked, catching Adora fiddling with the Monopoly horse for the umpteenth time since they laid it out. Adora flushed, the heat rising all the way up to her ears. Bow was giving her doe eyes.

"Your mom's flight got delayed because of the storm didn't it?" He said with a knowing tone, that just made Adora turn even redder.

"Ah, gross. Keep it in your pants until later Adora." Glimmer said with a laugh, nudging her. Adora buried her face into her hands. "I know you two have, you know, by now. Gods, I knew the next day. You were practically glowing."

Bow leaned over and pecked his girlfriend on the cheek. "They are so cute, aren't they? Catra acts all casual about it but they still

both get flustered so easy."

Adora peeked out from between her fingers. Yeah, sex talk was one thing, clinically she could talk about it, but sex with *Catra* , whoa boy, that was another story all together. "She's staying the night okay? I'm… we've never gotten to do that. Ya know, fall asleep together after."

"Adora…" Glimmer said seriously. "Why do you think I stopped sleeping down there during sleepovers?"

"We're not doing that in your basement Glim! That's like… weird!"

Adora was temporarily saved from embarrassment by a knock on the door. She bounded off the couch and towards the front door. Catra would help her fend off this assault, or make it worse, depending on her mood. If it was the second one, well, she knew just how to shut Cat up. Adora suspected that she did that on purpose sometimes just to make Adora kiss her.

She swung open the door and was swept up in a hug, just not by the person Adora had been anticipating. She stepped aside so Perfuma and Scorpia could shuffle their way in and take off the many layers of warmth the day called for. As Adora shut the door she eyed the clock. Catra should be here soon.

"It's your turn there spacy." Scorpia said softly. Adora tore her eyes away from the clock and rolled the dice, mindlessly moving her piece and handing Perfuma the rent that was due. "You said she was walking right?" Adora nodded at Scorpia's question, now looking at the quickly dimming light on the other side of the window. A knot had formed in her stomach. It was almost five, and once the sun dipped down all the way it was going to be even colder. "I'm sure Wildcat is just struggling with the snow. You know how short she is, practically waist high on her!"

She felt bad for not laughing, felt silly for worrying, but another hour slipped by with no frosty arrival at the door, and no response

to Adora's many texts. The call she made went unanswered. She'd given up on playing and took a seat next to the window, the snow was still falling, and the plow had gone by twice already. The mountain of snow pushed up at the curb was obstructing her view down the street. "I'm going to go look for her." Adora said abruptly, but before she could stand her phone started to ring. Relief washed over her as she answered her cell, Catra's name glowing on the screen.

"Cat, thank god. Where are you?"

"Hello." Said a deep voice, a voice Adora didn't recognize. It was calm and even as it continued. "Is this Adora Grey?" He asked.

"Yes." Adora said sharply, suddenly frozen in place. Why was her heart pounding so hard? Catra must have dropped her phone, or left it at the library. Weird though, that someone would find it and call her, or maybe they saw Adora's last text.

"This is officer Ro. You're listed as Miss Weaver's emergency contact on her cellular device. Would you be able to make it up to Krytis hospital? One of our officers could escort you or possibly give you a ride due to the storm."

"What… what happened." The phone nearly fell from her hand, it was shaking so badly. "Is Catra.. okay? Catra's okay."

"Ma'am, I'm sorry but I can't tell you much over the phone."

Adora looked numbly out the window, turning away from everyone who was staring at her from the edge of their seats. She watched the soft razorblades fall, her heart beating too loudly to hear anything the strange voice was saying.

—-

“Yeah.” Catra said smugly. “You love it though.” She finished righting herself in the back seat, bringing her ukulele up into position again and gestured at the real thing resting just behind the driver seat.

Adora tilted her head in question, glancing from it to Catra. “Pick it up, dummy. Someone is going to have to take up the asshole mantle for me. We can’t let Glimmer go unfettered for too long. She’ll gain too much power.”

Adora rolled her eyes for what felt like the unpteenth time today and picked the instrument up.

Observing how Catra held it, she cradled it the same way. Adora pressed a finger to the fret Catra also had held down. “Is there anything about me you didn’t store in that big brain of yours? Is that why your forehead is so big? Full of my secrets.”

“Just teach me the song, jerk.”

“You already know it.”

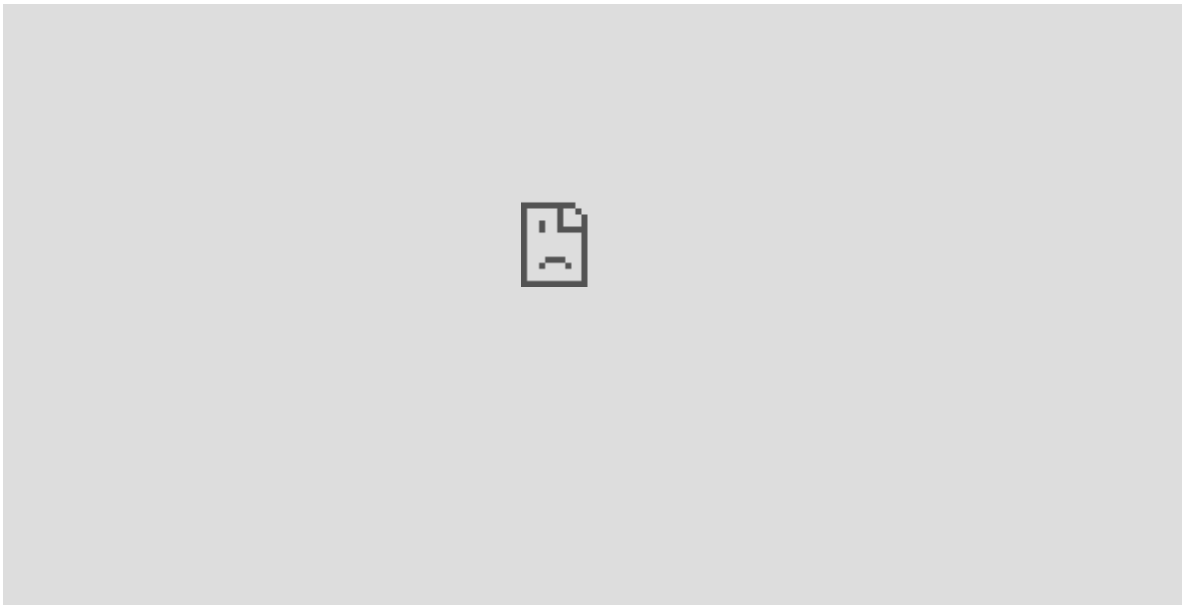
It was clumsy, but Adora mirrored the movement Catra was making. Her hands sliding across the strings, the same ones Cat touched so gently, roughly and wildly, just like how Catra used to touch her. Cat’s fingertips weaving magic through her veins, lifting her higher and higher.

“Ready?” Catra asked once they played through the cords a few times. Adora didn’t like the way she asked, with those eyes piercing through her. She didn’t know if she’d ever be ready. Adora could sit in this car forever, singing with her.

She found herself laughing again anyway as they played the first cord together. They both sang out at the same time, notes broken with giggles between.

“Sparkles eats Bow for breakfast. It gives her that shimmer and shine. Down on her knees she dines. Oh! A taste so divine.

Because Sparkles eats Bow for breakfast. Starts her day, the only way. Oh the price my eyes had to pay. Because Sparkles eats Bow for breakfast…"



Femboy Himbo · Sparkles Eats Bow for Breakfast

(or click here if your browser doesn't support HTML 5)

Chapter End Notes

Huge thank you to dude.adora for turning this song into music and hosting it for me! Also a big thanks to truckeecheeze for singing this for me! Those are their names on Tiktok. Go follow them on there for amazing She-Ra content.

As always, kudos, comments and sharing are always a huge boost for me. I cried 20 times writing this thing (i kept a counter) so knowing my tears were worth it is a great way to keep me a chugging along.

Saying this again, trust me.

Concentrate

She brought the water to her face, its cool touch soothing her red eyes. Spinnerella ever so gently had urged Adora to take a short walk so the nurses could keep to their schedule and change out the catheter. Adora knew it wasn't the day for that, they'd done that last week. Air, Adora needed air. What the social worker didn't know was that Catra was also waiting for her at the end of the hallway. That's where she always waited when Adora went to visit her. Adora looked at her in the bathroom mirror, leaning so casually against the wall behind her.

"If I'd just gone… runaway with you when you asked." Catra kicked off the wall and sighed, placing her hand on the sink near hers.

"If you'd given in to my stupid impulse, where would we be, Adora? You wanted me, us, to graduate highschool. How awful of you." Adora scowled at her, biting the inside of her cheek. *Why* couldn't she just agree on one damn thing? *Why* did she keep pushing back?

"We could be anywhere, Cat, and I wouldn't care. If we were pitching a tent somewhere right now, stealing eggs from nests for breakfast. I wouldn't care."

Catra scoffed and glared right back. "That's bull and you know it Adora. What? You'd think I'd actually be happy dragging you away from BU like that? From a future? I was just scared, you're the level headed one here."

Why ? *Why* couldn't she be the scared one? *Why* couldn't she be the one to do something stupid. What if she wanted too? Wasn't that the point of no maps, no solid plans? Take a risk, Adora. Skip school, Adora. Don't study your life away, Adora. She slammed the fauset down, the metal creaking as she continued to push it well after the water stopped. She didn't want to go to this fucking

school, she didn’t want to fucking leave. She needed room to breathe.

“You wouldn’t be dead Catra!” Blue and gold eyes held hers, blankly reflecting the fire in her own. Catra didn’t move, not a twitch of her lip, her face was emotionless.

“So you finally admit huh?” Catra said quietly, barely a whisper. Adora’s face fell, the fury in her hands faded and she finally released the faucet, a tiny stream of water now leaking down from the seam.

“No.” She reached to grab Catra’s shoulders, the fake stepping back quickly.

“Don’t Adora, you can’t handle it right now.”

“Stop telling me what I can and can’t handle Cat. You’re not dead.” She didn’t mean to say it, and it wasn’t true. Catra was just down the hall, breathing, remembering, hearing. Probably thinking how silly she was for spending so much time there, talking to her when she couldn’t talk back, not yet.

“Adora, we’ve been through this already. Think, you know the odds. You and your research. Trying to find answers, solutions.” Adora said nothing as Catra’s eyes searched her. It was like Cat was pleading with her, but it wasn’t the same as that fight they had on horror movie night. Adora had never seen this look on her before. Catra didn’t look desperate, she was calm, her tone careful.

“3% Dor.”

“It said 2 to 3 weeks, and you’d be back. That you’d wake up.”

“It said, baby. Not the doctors. The internet, in all its vastness, isn’t my doctor. How long has it been now Adora? How many months?”

She wanted to grab Catra by that stupid leather jacket and shake her. If she'd just stayed home, if Catra had just come straight to Glimmers. She wouldn't have to..

"Have to what Dor?" Catra asked sincerely. For some reason, she didn't know, she knew almost everything, but she didn't know what tomorrow was. Maybe because Adora didn't know either. She still didn't know where, when or if at all when she got behind the wheel. While it was Adora's plan to go… somewhere, she didn't know if she could.

"I don't have any reflexive response." Adora turned away from her and toward the door.

"I'm not talking to you right now." She slammed the bathroom door behind her, footsteps followed her down the hall anyway.

"Tell me what that means Adora. 3%. I'm dead, don't you get it? No responses Adora. Dr. Netossa said that higher brain activity didn't necessarily change my situation Dor. It could be years, it could be never. It could've been a fluke."

Adora had to stop herself from running, long strides weren't long enough. She needed her to shut up. She didn't care. The chance of getting struck by lightning was 1 in 500,000, or 0.0002%. That didn't mean that Adora was going to go stand in a field during a storm. People got hit all the time.

Adora reached Catra's room, and the one behind her backed away, finally silent. She never came in there, was never visible where Adora could see both of them. She didn't need to ask why that was. There was no arguing there, she knew she wouldn't be able to handle it.

She shut the door and leaned against it, watching her lay there. It looked just like she was sleeping. So peaceful, so quiet, so unlike Catra. The Catra out there could shove it. *Why* shouldn't she hold on to that 3 for all its worth? People played the lottery every week

and lost, and yet they kept playing. Three was a very, very large number.

“I love you.” Adora said, exasperated, as she took her seat and Catra’s hand. She had about two hours left before Bow would drive up here to get her. “Even if you are a dick sometimes.”

___

One in Ten. Adora glanced away from the presence in her room and at the words she’d scrawled on the whiteboard mounted by her door. Every assignment and due date erased. One in ten. All it would take is an eye opening and that number would be even better. One in five.

The streetlight outside her window illuminated half her room. Normally she’d walk over and close the blinds before she laid down. She couldn’t bring herself to walk over to the window though, not with Catra sitting at the desk, backwards in the chair, head in her hand, silently staring at Adora.

As week three passed with no changes she appeared one morning. Adora was brushing her teeth, dully observing the dark circles under her eyes. She looked down to rinse her toothbrush, making sure all the remnants washed down and when she looked back up there Catra was in the mirror. Same leather jacket, ratty red shirt with a big curly gold Q barely visible, and black skinny jeans from the photo, leaning against the doorframe to the bathroom.

“Hey Adora.”

Wherever she was, so was Catra. Catra hadn’t said much more yet, mostly just watched her.

Sometimes she was amused, sitting on the edge of the teachers desk like she had today. Adora looked up from her test to catch her smirking, proud that she was distracting the ever diligent student. Adora could barely focus on the questions anyway, letters jumbling into things she knew were supposed to be words. Words that supposedly meant things. Her mind was elsewhere. Her thoughts are tucked away in her backpack. They were in the sticky notes that poked out of a green folder. Her attention nestled into that stuffed folder, between the printed pages that were covered in highlights, circled sentences and hastily scribbled notes on their edges.

Who gave a shit about the practices of the roman government when there was a man six years ago, thought to be in a vegative state who woke up asking for a cup of coffee? Fuck Ceasar and his July's, all the pre season trainings that filled that month and the months that followed. Who cared when she could be keeping Catra company? That's what was actually important right now. Saying her name, telling her stories of things they'd done together. Multiple books and websites said that unless the mind was completely gone, hearing a loved one talk stimulated brain activity.

Catra loved her, she knew that without a doubt. They'd said it enough times to each other, those words did have meaning. "I love you" held countless promised futures. "I love you." Was the breath that tucked her in at night, phone next to their pillows when the other couldn't sleep. Those three words painted the colors of kisses, dreams and fairytale trips across the country. Adora made a point to hold her hand when she said it, hoping her touch along the words would magically spark her to life. They didn't, but hopefully the hours she'd spent in her room this past week, now that she was allowed to, would help her brain start to remember the pathways to consciousness.

Maybe if she'd been allowed in there sooner, Catra would have opened her eyes by now. Adora wouldn't want to wake up either if she heard Bitchatrix spitting bullshit in the same room.

Adora snapped her head up from her desk at Catra's voice. A few of their classmates glanced up from their own test at her sudden movement.

"Adora!" She yelled again, pointing at the clock on the wall. "Concentrate."

This specter that followed her hadn't said a peep since. Now she just sat there, in the artificial moonlite of the street lamp as Adora watched her from bed. Catra sighed and slumped forward to rest her chin on the back of the chair.

"Catra?" Had she gone off the deep end? She looked so real, like if she stormed up to her Adora could squeeze her close. Like Adora could pick her up and spin her around once more.

Just like that day in the park. They folded the quilt and packed it into Catra's makeshift picnic basket. Adora had snatched it up before Catra could grab it. Catra sang for her, did all this for her, she could at least carry it back to the car. "My girlfriend is so chivalrous." Adora immediately dropped the basket and scooped Catra up into her arms, pulling her close and kissing her again. "Girlfriend" had gotten just the reaction from Adora that she'd been going for. She always knew how to do that, push and pull the levers of Adora's mind. For the most part Catra used that knowledge for good rather than evil. Perhaps she had too strong a hold, if Catra was still guiding her from a hospital bed.

"Oh, so now you acknowledge me." Catra said with a smirk. "Wondered how long I was going to get the silent treatment." Adora took a shuddering breath, digging her fingers further into the sheet balled up in front of her.

"What are you doing here Catra?" Adora asked quietly, unsure who or what exactly she was talking too. Yes it was her girlfriend, but was it really her? Could that even be possible? Hadn't she seen that in a movie somewhere? The soul leaving the body even though it was technically still alive, a hospital drama of some sort.

“I guess you need me or something. You *looove* me.” She replied, swinging her feet at the sides of the chair. Adora could hear the brush of jeans swiping against the legs. How could she be hearing that if Catra wasn’t there? No one else could see or hear her, that was obvious. No one paid mind in class as Catra fidgeted with different items on their teachers desk. Adora had to train herself to ignore Catra all together when she was around Glimmer and Bow. She’d seen them follow her eyes when she kept glancing at the chair in front of the TV in the Moon’s basement. Catra had just laid there, like she was waiting for Adora to say something about her presence.

“I need you to get back in your body.”

Catra laughed from her seat, it was bittersweet, leaving Adora’s ears aching for more. When was the last time she’d heard Catra laugh? The day of the accident? It hasn’t been that long really. Days, weeks, without hearing her felt like an eternity when she was always at least a phone call away.

“That’s not how it works sweetie. I’m sorry.” Catra said softly, descaling the playful tone in her voice that slipped in with each word. “This isn’t some ghost movie. You know what I am. You thought it already. If I could though, you know I would follow you around. As if I’d ever leave you alone.”

Adora swallowed hard, prompting a pitying look from her girlfriend, or rather, her own personal projection of Catra. It wasn’t actually her, it was just her own broken heart sitting in her bedroom. That’s what she’d been afraid of.

“Why?” Adora asked curtly. She knew there was no answer. That didn’t mean she did want to scream it. Yell at the top of her lungs while wandering the streets until the sun rose to mock her with the start of another day. Another day that Catra’s odds got worse. The 15th was slipping away from her, a milestone that she’d set on a pedestal. The 15th of March. By then surely. It would all be over by then, Catra was just dramatic and liked to wait until the last minute.

“Why?” She repeated, quietly this time. Catra slumped in her chair.

“Why, what Adora?”

If this Catra really was a specter of her own creation then she should already know what Adora was asking. Why did this happen? Why Catra? Why was she not waking up? They had so much planned, everything had fallen perfectly. Catra got into the same college as Adora. Fuck, even if she hadn’t Adora would have thrown all that aside. It’s not like it was ever her own plan anyway, Catra knew that too but they were actually going to make it. No need for backup plans, no choices to make.

Catra didn’t say anything, there just was no answer. She was wrong though, there was always an answer, a solution. Hope had taught her that. Adora just had to find it. There had to be something more she could do, something she could offer.

Adora doesn’t sleep. Not a wink. Yet, she doesn’t say anything else either. What was safe to say, when her mind made a voice of its own? She just stares at Catra all night, occasionally glancing at her whiteboard until the sun slowly rises on the 16th. Catra basks in the morning light pouring in through the window, stretching as if the chair was actually uncomfortable.

It’s Saturday. She really should head to the hospital. Bow already texted her, asking when she wanted to be picked up. It’s just a few words, but she doesn’t have the will to respond. How could she walk in there? It was the 16th.

Four weeks, no responses. Not a jab or prod could move Catra. Each breath could be the last she took on her own. As her brain healed that could also change for the better. She had to get better, probably a little better already. It was the 16th. It was just an estimation anyway, a generalization, she didn’t need to erase those ones from her whiteboard yet.

A rap on the door forced her eyes back open, not entirely sure when they had closed. “Adora?” Hope called out from the other side. She found Catra still sitting in that chair, swinging her feet, looking at her expectantly. Hope had been more lenient with her lately, not every call for Adora required a prompt response. Usually no matter what she was doing or where she was, Hope was to be answered, but that hadn’t been the case since Adora’s count of the days had started. She clenched her jaw. Adora hadn’t talked to her adopter at all in at least the last two days as *the* date approached.

“Breakfast is ready. I’m not bringing it up to you this time. You need to come out of your room at least.” Contrary to her words, Hope’s voice was unusually soft. Catra rolled her eyes and scowled at the door. Hope waited for a moment and for once Adora didn't even feel the pull to respond. She just felt contempt. “Have I made myself clear Adora? We need to talk.”

“ *We need to talk* .” Catra said high and whining as she stood up from the desk. “Oh yeah, that's just a perfect thing to say to someone with more anxiety issues than a mouse in a room full of cats.” Adora cringed, still fearful that Hope was going to catch Catra in her room. Catra crossed the room and stood in front of the door flipping it off, the offending finger following the sounds of footsteps down the hallway. “Anxiety issues that you gave her, *BY THE WAY* .” She finally lowered her hand finally and turned back around to face Adora. “Your mother, I swear to god.”

Hope ended up bringing dinner to the door that night, and the morning after, and then for the days that followed. Adora washed the plates in her bathroom sink, placing the clean dishes just outside of her room. Adora knew that her mother’s conversation with the school principal happened at the end of her hallway deliberately, but she didn’t care. Adora just needed more information, and the internet had plenty. Even better than that though, she had Catra.

Catra sat across from her, flipping through Adora’s notes, pencil dangling from her mouth. “You know, this has been kind of nice.

We never get this much time together during the school year."

"I know right?" Adora smiled up at her, knees bouncing restlessly as she sat criss crossed on the floor, side by side with her girl. "And you're really making quick work of a lot of this. I would appreciate it though if you stopped drawing titties on the margins."

Catra stuck her tongue out. "Nah, who else is gonna make you smile. Your pout is cute and all, but I think all this reading is giving you forehead wrinkles." Adora shook her head and looked back down at the paper published back in the 60's. Sure it was outdated, but they had some interesting, and sometimes disturbing (she covered those with black sharpie) ideas. "Why don't we take a break Dor? I kind of feel like going on a walk."

"Mmm, can you wait a little bit longer Cat? I'm almost finished with this stack." Adora thumbed the papers. "Fifteen or so to go."

"Babe… I love you, but I don't think I can handle your stench for another fifteen pages. Please, for my nose. Go shower." Adora put the paper down and crossed her arms, narrowing her eyes suspiciously at her toothy, pleading smile.

"You can't smell."

"You don't know that. You smell worse than after practice. You smell like Lonnie's socks. The locker rooms got so much better after she graduated. Good luck with that by the way. You get to play with her again at BO, I mean BU."

She fell asleep again without realizing it. The hot water had made her comforter look so alluring. When she tipped toed across her paper strewn floor to her bed, it was only ever meant to be a quick break. She didn't know what time it was, or day. Adora picked up her phone, ignoring the large number of read but unanswered messages in the corner. Her friends were worried about her, they were worried about the wrong person. March

26th. 2:53 am. Adora looked back at her whiteboard, the circle around the 15th, the one in ten.

“I think..” Catra said from the foot of her bed where she sat with her back against the wall, knees tucked to her chest. “That the best source of information is right from the horse’s mouth.”

“They won’t talk to me. I’m not… kin or whatever.”

“Well, when has that ever stopped you when it came to me? You’re family Adora, my love. You might just be my girlfriend, but you're more than that. We should’ve eloped the moment you turned 18.” Catra tisked and smacked her leg. “Should’ve knocked you up I guess.”

“You’re ridiculous.”

“Not half as much as you. You already picked out possible apartments for the end of our freshman year. Only ones that allowed cats too. What are you? A lesbian or something?” She looked surprised when Adora swept the covers off of herself and slid off the bed. “What are you doing?”

Adora stepped around the papers, almost dancing her way to her closet. Catra was right, if she wanted answers, she should go to the source. Seeing Catra just lay there wouldn’t change anything in her mind, she could take it. Those numbers didn’t need to change just because Catra hadn’t.

She slid open the closet door, immediately eyeing Catra’s hoodie. She’d been wearing her clothes sparingly, so she didn’t need to wash them, so they still smelled like her. Adora pulled it off the hanger and buried herself in it. A hint of Old Spice, but mostly just Catra. If sunshine and moonlight had a smell, that would be Catra.

“You corny ass.”

Adora hid her blush by slipping it on, the sleeves were too short, the shoulders too tight, but that didn’t matter. She started to pull

on a pair of sweatpants and stopped, eyeing the pile of things she'd collected on the floor of her closet. Fuck, fuck, fuck. The hospital had to wait a little longer. She hadn't been to Catra's house in ten, no eleven days. What else had that bitch thrown away? Please let her have not missed that.

Adora sprinted across her room and flung her window open. Her fingers were shaking as she fumbled trying to get the screen off. "Whoa, whoa hold up Adora. Hey, what are you doing!?"

"Your ukulele!" Adora's voice cracked, she couldn't get her fingers around the lip of the frame. "I can't let her-" she growled in frustration, panic. "Come on, get off of here. I can't let her throw it away." Adora pressed against the mesh, usually Catra pressed from the outside to get the frame to stick out, she didn't have time to try and get it off carefully. The wires popped and bent around her fingers, giving her just enough room to grab it and yank.

"Adora, you don't even have shoes on. That's a long ass walk! You're going to get frostbite." She was half out the window, one leg over the freezing branch. It was slippery, but they'd done this dozens of times before. Even before she and Catra started dating. It took some coaxing to get her to sneak out the first few times, but now she barely thought about it when Hope was asleep. Sometimes Glimmer and Bow waved her down too, as long as they were quiet her mom never suspected a thing. Adora was a *good* girl. Good girls don't sneak out, they also don't take their mother's car in the middle of the night. The keys should be her coat pocket hanging by the garage door.

"I'm not walking, Cat. I have some old shoes in the garage." Catra leaned out the window, Adora already half monkied down toward the safety of where the branch joined with the trunk of the tree.

"Then what are … Oh. OH! FUCK YEAH! GTA, I'm fully behind this now."

“I’m not stealing it.” Adora hissed at the cold when her feet hit snow. “Just borrowing it for a while.”

“Okay, but why didn’t you just go through the house? She’s asleep.”

Catra’s window was much easier to open. The trash can outside was empty, which wasn’t really a good sign. Adora lifted herself through the frame and onto Catra’s bed. She turned around to help Catra through, but before she could twist around all the way, Catra was already standing in the middle of the room, staring at her new bare walls.

Adora was distracted though, her pillow was still there, her blanket. The room already had a musty smell to it, from all the recently disturbed dust, but the pillow and blanket had her sweet, familiar scent. She was absolutely taking these with her.

“My posters…” Catra mumbled.

“I’m sorry Cat. I should have been here.”

Catra shook her head. “She probably tore them down. Nothing to save. Don’t worry about it.”

“We’ll get you new ones.” Adora promised, painfully parting from the bed. She strode over to Catra’s closet. It was open and empty except for a few crumbled pieces of paper. Adora grabbed one, and flattened it against the wall, using the dim light from the window to read. It was a packing list, for something, the what didn’t matter though. She missed her handwriting. The smooth, curly letters, each stroke strong and precise-

“Adora come on, it’s nothing. Focus, we came here for a reason.” Catra groaned when she pocketed it but began searching on her own. Adora looked under the bed, in now mostly empty drawers, there was no ukulele.

“I’m not giving up yet.” She muttered, Catra nodded in agreement, pointing to her bedroom door.

“It’s been cold. It might be in the entryway, if she decided to toss it recently.” Catra whispered as they crept forward. A slim chance, but Adora would take it. Catra always complained about how stuffy and hot their house would be in summer. Beatrix hated the cold. She had some sort of circulation issue apparently. Adora remembered because of Catra’s “Just *pray harder* to *fix it* and turn the damn AC on woman.” grumblings on hot summer night phone calls.

It was dark, most of the curtains drawn shut to keep out the street light. Adora treaded carefully toward the glow coming from the living room. She’d only been in this house a handful of times, but she in general knew which way to go. Catra mimed tipping a bottle to her mouth, shutting her eyes in feign sleep. That’s right, she often fell asleep on the couch. Beatrix liked to watch the news at night so she could tell the congregation just how continually wicked the world was when she went to work in the morning.

Catra tip-toed toward the couch, peering over its edge before waving Adora over. “Yup, she’s out cold. Too much blood of Christ again.” Adora started to walk past her to the mud room when Catra let out a strained “Mom…” Adora followed her gaze to what had Catra still, stiff and stepping away. She squinted against the flashing glow of the television to the shelf above it.

There was a large cross on the wall, and at Jesus’s feet were photos she’d never seen before. Little frames encased sun spotted Polaroids of a giddy looking little girl in her momma’s lap. Another of Catra at maybe six years old, her canines even more outrageously big compared to her dirt covered little face beaming up at the camera with a toy fishing pole held high with pride. The third frame, it looked to be Cat’s school photo from her freshman year. When the cameraman told her to smile she just stared stony faced, but Adora had waited for her so they could walk to the

lunchroom together. It was the first time Adora had ever flipped anyone off, she knew it would make Catra laugh. It was the only class photo in highschool that had Catra smiling in it. Behind the pictures though, Adora saw brassy knobs and a sheen of familiar stickers.

Catra got there first, a contrasted shadow against the harsh light of the TV. "She… she probably thinks this is better for me. Being trapped in that room." Adora almost tried to… but stopped herself and stood next to her instead. She wanted to wrap Catra up in her arms, to hold her, run her fingers through hair and place kisses wrapped with "I love you"s.

"I guess though…" Catra turned and looked at her mother's too peacefully sleeping form on the couch. "In her own fucked up way, she loves me. The idea of me, anyway."

"Should I leave it here?" That got Adora a stern look and strong head-shake.

"Absolutely not. Take it Dor. It's yours."

"Until you wake up." Adora added. Catra gave her a sweet, somber smile.

"Sure, until I wake up." Catra faced the wall again, looking up at the large cross hanging there. "Can you do something for me? Before we head to the hospital?"

Hope was an atheist, and Adora supposed she was too but still she found herself looking up and muttering, "Trust me, she deserves it." as she wrestled to hang Mr. Christ upside down noiselessly.

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Adora flipped through the mapquest pages sitting in the passenger seat. If she was going to the university, it would take

around six hours. A bit more depending on how much longer she sat here. Adora printed out alternate routes too, in case traffic got overwhelming. She expected Catra to make some comment on her still being indecisive or on the maps themselves, to toss them out the window, but instead Catra was sprawled out in the back seat, plucking at the strings and looking morose.

It took a few minutes of Adora watching, following the little rocks of her feet as Catra thought before she spoke up. “I’m sorry, for yesterday, at the hospital. I wouldn’t have given you such a hard time if I knew what today was.”

“It’s okay, Cat. Nothing to forgive.”

She looked up at Adora, pausing her careless plucking.

“Exactly.” Catra said, and returned her attention to the strings.

Clemency

Chapter Notes

> Just a heads up, there's depictions of physical trauma in this ch. Not abuse or anything, just what happened.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Every last minute, Adora squeezed out every last minute. She watched the sunset in silence, almost silence. The tick of the clock on the wall became louder and louder as the hues of the sky changed into deep reds and golds chasing the bright blue away. All it did was remind her of how many months it's been since she'd seen her eyes.

Bow had texted already, that he and Glimmer were waiting outside, but that she could take her time. Adora had stood up to leave but found herself stuck. She'd curled Catra's fingers around her own, and as they offered no resistance, Adora still couldn't let go.

She watched her breathe, occasionally flicking to the monitor when she took a deep breath. That was the only time that beautiful heart of hers changed at all, the pattern breaking just a little.

Catra was so worried, so scared to be left behind. Not just by Adora, but by everyone. That all of her friends would leave and she'd be stuck here, ringing out the same old croons or worse, that she'd be out there without a familiar face in sight. It was the only thing that Catra Weaver was stupid about, not knowing how much she meant to those who loved her. As if they all could just move on and forget about her. However it would have played out, if Catra went to a different college, went and moved across the country, built a rocket and launched herself into space, she'd never be alone, not really.

But this room, with its tacky walls, fake flowers and obnoxiously loud clock, felt incredibly lonely. Adora promised her that she wasn't going to leave her behind. She'd've snuck Catra into the dorm if she had to, get a single and spend the nights together. Adora stared at the heart monitor, Catra's hand heavy in hers. She was about to do what Catra feared the most, abandon her, and Cat couldn't even be upset about it.

If there was some God she could make a deal with, call up the devil and trade all she worked for just to wake Catra up, she would, but there wasn't. For the first time in her life there was no solution, no answer to find, no way to win. She did the best she could during her visits. Even if they fell on deaf ears, Adora recounted their precious memories to try and blow that red hot coal deep in Catra's mind into flame. There was no smoke to signal if her efforts amounted to anything. All she could do now was wait, but Adora couldn't wait here anymore. The Catra standing out in the hall was right about one thing, that Catra would be mad as hell if Adora threw this chance away. She was going to go out and start building that future they always talked about, but that didn't mean she wanted too.

Adora leaned as far over as possible without moving their arms and pressed her lips to Catra's forehead. "I'm sorry, sweetheart." She said against her skin, Catra's hair was barely long enough again to brush against Adora's cheek. "This isn't goodbye Cat. I'm not abandoning you." Even as she said it, she didn't believe the words. It felt like a convenient lie to tell, just because she'd be back didn't make her *choosing* to go any less true. That's what she was doing, going on without her. "I promise. It'll be a while, but I'll be back, okay?"

Adora finally let Catra's hand drop back to the mattress. She wrapped her arms around head and shoulders and half laid across her, careful not to put too much pressure on her chest or move her still head. "I'll see you soon. Maybe even tell you about some of the places I crossed off our list." She kissed her forehead again, paying no mind to the hot streaks making their way down her face. "I don't know yet, I don't know if I can do it but I'm going to

try. I love you so much Cat. I hope you can forgive me. I know it might feel like I'm abandoning you but I promise I'm not. I'll be back, over break. I'll come back the second you wake up."

She lifted herself up slowly. "You're going to wake up."

Adora ripped herself from the bed and grabbed at the door handle, wiping the tears from her face before opening it. She needed the momentum to keep going forward. She couldn't stop walking, or she'd never make it to the exit. She passed by Catra who was waiting at the end of the hall, surprised by how upset Adora still looked. Most of her visits since graduation Adora hadn't cried or parted this distressed. There was the fit here or there, but Adora usually collected herself in time to head back home.

"Did you finally accept it? Are you going to stop wasting your time here Dor?" Catra asked as she jogged behind her.

"It's not a waste of time Catra!" A nurse she hadn't noticed walking by stopped, startled. Adora turned her face away, still rubbing the reds from her eyes. And no, she wasn't going to accept shit. When she leaves tomorrow, if she actually goes at all, it's not going to be because she gave up. If she took those keys and drove, it wasn't moving on, it was moving forward. As long as Catra was breathing, there was still a chance, no matter how slim it may be.

"Why are you being so mean today?" Adora asked once they were alone in the elevator. It's not like Catra was sunshine and rainbows. This Cat was usually the same level of onry that Adora loved, but not today for some reason. Today she barely seemed like Catra at all.

"I don't know. You tell me Dor."

The newly acquired ukulele, the pillow and the blanket were safely tucked away in the backseat of her mom's SUV. Weirdly, Catra was in the passenger seat once more. She wasn't used to seeing her over there. Adora hadn't driven much since she'd gotten her license. Catra had let her drive the Lincoln a few times, but that was much lower, and much easier to drive. Hope's car felt like she was steering a brick. Catra was keeping an eye on the lines for her which helped immensely. Thankfully the roads were clear aside from a few slick spots that Catra pointed out to her well before they reached the shiny black patches of road.

Adora wasn't brave enough to get on the highway, not with it being such an early and odd hour. Not when she had technically stolen her mother's car and just got done breaking into Catra's house. Bored small town cops would probably pull her over for the slightest swerve or weave. All it would take is a flash of red and blue lights and Adora would probably panic them into the ditch.

"So, what are we doing when we get there?" Catra asked, her eyes still peeled for black ice and the glowing eyes of deer that were just waiting to leap out in front of them from the bush. Adora opened her mouth to say something, and kept it open. She had no clue.

"Umm? Adora, you were just planning on barging in there and doing what exactly? I know I'm all for living in the moment but that's for like… life n shit, not espionage."

"Fuck." Adora let off the gas, the car slowing and coming to a stop as she pulled over to the side. "What am I doing, Cat?" The lights from town were visible now through the trees. It was about to be go time and she had nothing. The hospital in their little offshoot didn't have the medical expertise to take care of her, when the ambulance picked her up her injuries were bad enough that they risked the extra time on the highway so the neurosurgeon in the main hospital could treat her. She hadn't explored much of the place on her own, and Adora realized then that she didn't even know how to get to the hospital from the backroad.

"There's signs. Just drive through town until you see the road signs guiding you to the hospital." Catra turned to look at Adora, who was still frozen, staring at the distant lights. "You think you'll find answers there? I believe you." Catra was tapping her foot anxiously on the floor mat. "I'll think of something. You have an invisible girlfriend to help you babe. Just… just get back on the road. This isn't a safe place to park." Adora nodded and started easing back onto the pavement. "I mean, you could just tell them your comatose girlfriend is standing next to you. That'll get you through the front door at least."

It was nearly 5 am by the time she made it to the hospital. It would have been sooner but the discovery of a twenty tucked away in the sun visor in case emergencies caused a pit stop. One pit stop, and a plan. Adora balanced the coffees on top of the box of donuts, as she tried to quiet her heart. The nurses in the ER shouldn't recognize her, they'd only seen her the one night. The other nurses on Catra's floor hopefully weren't here yet, except for the one that kept complaining about long hours every time Adora had walked by. They better be, or Adora was fucked.

"Hold up." Catra said, making Adora's heart nearly leap from her chest, the coffee's sliding to the edge. "Check the trash cans. There's got to be some hospital bands you can pocket. If you wrap the ends together, you can wear it and just look like a lost patient once you're on a different floor."

Adora set the box on the ground, and looked to see if anyone could catch her digging through the trash. The security guard on the other side of the emergency room doors was busy chatting away with someone out of view. She pushed the lid in, it must have been recently emptied but right next to an crumpled chip bag, was a torn hospital bracelet. She pocketed it, thankful that Sebastian, Hawk, was too impatient to cut it off at home. She couldn't claim the name, but at a glance it would do just fine to see it around her wrist.

Adora gathered the cover donuts and coffee. She already looked the part of travel worn, tired teenager so at least she didn't need to act. The security guard didn't give her any trouble as she walked through the metal detectors. She put her keys back into her pocket and headed to the check in.

A nurse was typing tiredly away at the keyboard, every second Adora had to wait the more nervous she got. What if that nurse wasn't in today? Should she just run for it? Offer to leave the coffee and treats up there anyway?

"What can I do for you young lady?" The woman finally turned and addressed her. "I'm guessing you're not here for a medical emergency." She said, nodding to Adora's armful.

"Thankfully, no." Adora said with only a slightly strained laugh.

Catra gave her a thumbs up as she leaned against the counter, trying to at least stay in Adora's periphery. "You got this babe."

"I'm DT's niece. I'm not sure if you know them, they usually work in the long term care wing. I figured the main entrance was locked this early in the day. I'm traveling through, and I was hoping to surprise them and say hello before getting back on the road." The nurse looked taken aback. Oh no.

"I didn't know DT had any siblings, or a niece even. Surprise, surprise, someone they don't gossip about."

Adora exhaled a little too quickly.

"Haha, yup. Chatterbox DT. Always loves talking about people. I remember this-" Adora clamped her mouth shut. Catra was waving at her wildly to stop. "Haha, well that's a long story, anyway… Is it alright if I head up there?"

"Sure, dear. Do you know the way? Need someone to walk with you?"

“Yup! I mean no! Ah, uh. I know the way. Just point me to the elevator and I’ll be fine. Thank you!” Adora gave her a wave, and almost offered her a donut from the box that the woman had been eyeing but Catra urged her forward after she’d received the only instruction necessary to get out of the ER.

Adora let the wall of the elevator hold her up as the doors closed. That was so easy! She pressed the button to the fourth floor, to the food court. From there she could find her way to the long term care wing. Adora found herself grinning like a madwoman. She was in, now she just had to figure out a way to get more information about Catra. It was time to fill in the blanks so she could focus her research, so she could get an accurate number to put on her whiteboard. It had to be higher than 3%.

Catra was just as smiley as she was, and she looked proud to boot. If Catra was impressed already, Adora was going to blow her away.

“ *So, what’s next, Adora?* ”

“ *I don’t know* .” She said with a deep breath. Those words didn’t scare her this time, they were a challenge, one she was ready to face. “We’ll figure it out.”

——

Adora had the maps spread out against the steering wheel when Catra spoke. She looked up in the rear view mirror to find Catra leaning forward expectantly, waiting for an answer, but Adora had missed the question, she’d been thinking, considering.

“What’s next, Dor?” Catra repeated, sounding bored.

“What do you mean?” Adora set the papers on the dash and turned to face her again.

“Are we going to talk some more? You’ve just been staring at that map for the last twenty or so.” Catra sighed and placed her ukelele back to where Adora had it resting behind her seat. “Or… are you actually going to drive this car?”

“I don’t know, Cat. I’m not sure if… if I can just go, go *anywhere* . What if…” Adora looked at the clock, and back at the route to Bright University on the dash. The pier wasn’t that far off the main highway, a baby step. “We could-“

“No, Adora.” Catra shook her head, dragging a palm across her face. With a sharp inhale Catra worried her lip for a moment. She eventually sat up straight and fixed herself into a less exasperated expression.

“No? No, what?” Adora asked, though she already knew the answer. Her throat was tight, she’d been sitting in this car for hours now for a reason. Catra gave her a soft smile, simultaneously proud and grave. “I said we.” Catra nodded and reached for the door handle.

“Cat!” Adora lunged forward, reaching for her, trying to stop her from leaving again. Her hand fell right through to the empty seat. She stilled, staring numbly at the empty back seat. Her heart was in her throat, she wasn’t ready.

“ *You can do this Adora.* ” Adora turned to see her favorite pair of eyes looking at her from the passenger seat. “You need to go, babe. Time isn’t going to stop just because you want it to. Life isn’t going to wait for me to get better, and neither can you.”

Adora pressed her lips together and let the wave of guilt, anxiety, and hurt wash over her. She took in that beautiful, lovely, and utterly perfect girl next to her. Adora felt like she was drowning and her lifeboat wasn’t on board. The acrid water rose until it couldn’t anymore, slipping down and out the open window. Catra sat stoic, paying no mind to the rush around them. The window was open, and the water wasn’t real.

Nothing would change if she just sat here, nothing but Adora would turn sour if she stayed. Catra wouldn't get better because of it, and neither would she. Catra was right, but she didn't want to leave like this, having their last moments tainted with fear boiling up inside of her. She could let it go, have it wash away, she just needed a few more minutes.

"Twenty minutes." She told Cat, surprised at the sternness in her own voice. "Just sit with me for twenty more minutes, and I'll go."

"Promise?" Catra asked, holding her hand out for Adora to take. Without hesitation Adora grabbed her hand and closed her eyes to remember the feeling. Once the tingling of warmth and the familiar texture of her skin was there, Adora opened them back up. Catra was smiling at her again, all fangs and full of love.

"I promise."

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"We'll figure it out." Catra said in agreement as the elevator doors opened. Adora barged forward, following the signs to the cafeteria. There were a few hospital staff sitting at the tables, looking worn and weary from their shifts likely coming to a close. Adora set the coffees and donuts down on the table next to them. She didn't need them anymore, but it seemed a waste to just throw it all away. If she actually ran into that nurse, it could be game over. There's no way she wouldn't recognize Adora. Hopefully none of the usual day staff was there either. "Have at it." Adora said to the two at the nearest table, and took off for the long term care wing.

“So, we both know my chart doesn’t have anything useful on it.” Catra said, nearly running backwards in front of Adora’s long determined strides. “The best bet is probably the nurses station, but…” Catra stopped and so did Adora when she heard voices coming from around the corner. “Fuck.” They both muttered and Adora quickly turned heel for the hallway they’d just passed. Adora just rounded it when the familiar voice became clear.

“Honey, I don’t know why I keep getting these shifts.” Adora slipped to the other side of the vending machine she’d spotted as they had walked by. “And I’ll be glad when I can go back to days. The weirdest things always happen in these witching hours. Why would someone claim to be my niece? I can’t believe Carol just let some girl in here to wander around.” Catra gave Adora a furtive look as the two RN’s walked past. “I bet she’s not even going this way. It’s weird, Carol said it was a pretty young thing, but all sorts try us for drugs these days. I doubt it’s that though, much easier to just get admitted. God knows what she’s up to. Maybe I have a fan? Oooh, a crazed love confession maybe?”

Catra bat her lashes at Adora who felt about two seconds away from passing out. “Oh, Adora! Already romancing my nurses? If you hook up in my room, tape my eyes open so I can watch.” Adora didn’t have time to smack herself for not assuming that the nurse at the check in wouldn’t call up because she was rolling her eyes too hard.

“If it’ll wake you up.” Adora grumbled as she unzipped her coat. Time for a costume change. She tucked the coat in between the machines, next to follow where her sweat pants, leaving her in just in Catra’s hoodie and pajama pants. A hospital gown would be nice, but it was cold in here. Just an inpatient going for a stroll. She pulled Sir Hawk’s bracelet from her pocket and twisted it around her wrist. Adora reached up and pulled down her hair tie, letting her long hair hang loose around her shoulders. If they got a physical description, Adora should be adequately different looking to not ping suspicion immediately.

Adora peeked around the corner, the tall, blonde nurse that had been her ticket in was far enough down the hall she felt safe to journey onward. “As I was saying before,” Catra started up again, resuming her position in front of her. “the nurse’s station. The computer has to be your best bet.”

Adora got in a nod before slowing down as a white coat came into view. It wasn’t necessary because the young looking doctor didn’t even bother to lift his head from the clipboard he was reading over. Still, it probably would have drawn attention if Adora had zipped by faster than the resident sweating bullets as he raced down the hall.

“It’s going to be password protected. The software will be anyway.” Adora told Catra as they rounded another corner, just a few steps away now from their grand plan to come to life.

Catra grinned at her. “That’s right. Look at you, Ms ‘Cat! Don't steal that!’ She gives me a hard time and is about to break even more laws in one night than I would dare to in a year. Amazing.”

Adora didn’t offer a response, well aware of just how badly this could turn out for her. She could be arrested for this, she could be banned from… Adora needed answers, and this was the only way to get information for those answers. “The system needs to be logged into already. I’ll have to take a chance on hoping they’ve pulled up one that’s actually going to be useful.” She stopped just outside the fire doors that she’d become familiar with. It’s not like Adora pre planned any of this. She didn’t bother looking up medical record programs in her hunt for coma information. If she hadn’t forgotten to check the trash at Catra’s house for the last week, they’d be more prepared, but Catra was with her, it would be fine. Cat was quick on her feet, and with her help, she would be too. “And I’ll have to guess how to use it also. I need to do something that gives me a little time.”

“Oooo” Catra hummed excitedly. “A distraction huh? I think you watched some spy movies without me.”

She opened the door slowly, letting Catra through first before gently guiding the door back to a silent close. The lights were dim and the halls devoid of people. Adora crept forward, hugging the wall until her target was in view. There was a nurse there she hadn't seen before, looking glassy eyed and fighting back a yawn. It was blessed luck that DT was here today, and even more lucky that DT was gone looking for her. Thanks after all, Carol. If she did get caught, maybe she would be able to get away without anyone recognizing her.

Catra stepped out into the open, and looked toward her room. "I have an idea." Adora couldn't respond, didn't want to risk being overheard so she just watched as Catra's mind was churning, her brows furrowed and rocking on her heels. "The pulse oximeter, the one on my finger, if that were to..." Adora's face grew hot with anger as she vehemently shook her head.

"Come on, Dor. Those things slip all the time, maybe not on someone who doesn't move, but it'll sound an alarm." Adora chewed on her lip. It would give her a window, but what if they thought Catra was actually coding, suffocating because she couldn't breathe on her own anymore?

"Then just put it somewhere obvious. It'll be a little mystery. Did I remove it? Was it just another residual seizure?" The seizures were an assumption on Adora's part, medication for it had been listed on the chart a nurse had set down as he'd changed the I.V by her bed. Adora didn't even want to think about Cat suffering like that.

Catra groaned at the glare she was reviving. She pointed to the nurse and Adora stood up a little to see the RN fiddling with something behind the desk, eyes fixed on the computer screen. "She's bored as fuck anyway. Do you want more information or not?" Catra stared her down, arms crossed and foot smacking against the tile impatiently. It's not like she could just pull the fire alarm without endangering everyone in the building.

Adora hadn’t been to see Catra for almost two weeks, and when she caught sight of the bed sheets through the open door she froze. She was crouched but all it would take is for that nurse to look up and this would be all for nothing. Adora turned to look at the walking, talking, all too real, Catra for support but instead of being behind her Cat was all the way back in front of the nurses station.

“Go! Do it! Do it n-” Her voice cut off as soon as Adora turned toward the door, where she saw in the creep of the dim fluorescent light the outline of Catra’s quiet form. Each footstep was loud to her, but not near as loud as the sound of Catra’s breathing as approached the bed. So what if she’s not awake? It doesn’t mean anything.

Adora stood up slowly, being careful of the I.V that sustained her. With the glow of the machines she could see the dressings that had previously been around Catra’s head were off, the work of thousands of stitches were visible along her shaved head. They looked like they’d been removed already, but Adora could see the raised puffy lines that were sure to scar. Little roots of the beginnings of wavy chestnut hair were sprouting again. The bruising around her eyes had started to yellow, no longer a deep purple from surgery. Catra was healing. Her body was healing. That beautiful mind was just going to take a bit longer. It didn’t matter that the pokes and prods went unanswered with a physical response. That mind was too busy repairing itself to bother with knocks at the door, and Adora was going to get the files to prove it.

She lifted Catra’s hand to her lips and pressed a kiss on her musician’s fingertips. It had been far too long since she was last here, but a proper visit had to sit on the back burner for now. This small affection would have to hold her over. When Adora got to the one encased in the plastic monitor she took a deep breath to quiet her heart. There was an empty room two doors down to hide in. As soon as the alarm went off and the nurse went past she’d get that proof she so desperately needed.

Even though she knew she only had a few seconds, Adora placed a kiss on that finger too before gently laying the hand back down and the reader on her chest, hopefully right where the nurse would see it. If she got caught, this might be her last time seeing Catra, but she couldn't linger. Adora just wouldn't get caught, she'd be back in here in no time to make up for the last week of absence.

Just seconds after Adora sprinted across the hallway and into the vacant room, the alarm from Catra's room rang out it's terrible cry. She closed her eyes and took a deep breath, it wasn't real. That sound would never happen for real. Tennis shoes squeaked against the tile, more than one pair Adora noted as three figures zipped by, the third more delayed. They were probably doing checks in other rooms or preparing meds. Even though it increased her chances of getting caught, Adora was relieved at the rapid response to Catra's orchestrated, false distress.

Catra was whooping in victory as Adora reached the counter, quickly zipping around to the other side of it. The mouse jumped across the screen from how badly her hand was shaking. Her aim found the X, closing the game of spider solitaire taking up the screen, and underneath were rows of different colored names attached to room numbers. "Don't scroll." Catra said hurriedly, practically vibrating out of her skin as she bounced around. "Use the search bar. Unless my mother woke up and had a heart attack already, I should be the only Weaver."

Adora found the empty bar at the top, just three letters in and her name popped up. She clicked on it and the view on the right changed. Seven different icons showed up on the right side of the screen and Adora had no clue what even half of them meant. She didn't need to though, the files icon was obvious enough. The pointer transformed into the spinning circle for what felt like a lifetime, and the alarm in Catra's room went quiet, followed by confused sounding chatter.

A grey box appeared, requesting login credentials. Adora's heart sank. Her time was almost up, and she had nothing to show for it.

“What now Catra?” She asked, looking up at her. Catra had her mouth scrunched to the side, as if she were about ready to start whistling. “Cat?! What do I do now?”

Catra flicked her eyes behind Adora. “Um, Dor. Stop talking.”

“ *Interesting.* ” DT said from behind her. Adora slowly straightened herself, shoving her hands into the pouch on Catra’s hoodie.

“I’m…” Adora’s voice cracked. She felt the band around her wrist still and pulled it off. It didn’t matter now. “I’m…” She’s what exactly? What the fuck could she say to get out of this? Catra was looking at her with a heartbroken expression.

She swallowed hard, the lump in her throat aching. How pathetic Adora must look right now. She failed, she failed Catra, again. If it weren’t for her, if it weren’t for Adora keeping her on that phone call... She could have left just a little sooner. If Adora hadn’t wanted to see her so bad, maybe she wouldn’t have left at all. They’d be getting ready for school. Catra would pick her up in two hours, and kiss her good morning. Now, Adora would probably never be allowed to see her again.

“Excuse me! What do you think you’re doing?” A frazzled nurse yelled as she came down the hall. Adora stiffened as an arm wrapped around her shoulders. DT’s hand took the mouse and exited back into the general hospital portal.

“I can’t believe I’m admitting this.” DT said with sigh and pulled Adora close to them. “But I do in fact have a sister. Tess, meet my niece-” Adora looked up at them, her mouth hanging open. Eerie, amused eyes met hers. “-Adora. Obviously, you can see what side of her family this gorgeous hair comes from.”

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“I’m so proud of you, you know that?” Catra broke the silence as their twenty minutes were coming to a close. “I want you to know

that. Hopefully, one day, you can tell me all about that super spy mission you went on. Wait until I've recovered enough though, I’m gonna want to jump your bones.”

Adora laughed, still shocked that she’d done it at all, and for how it had all turned out. Catra *would* find that sudden, wild decision hot on her. But really she’d just gotten lucky, that’s all. “But I got caught. I’m sure if it were you, you’d have figured it out.”

“Doesn’t matter, Dor. You did it. That was all you, my smart, clever girlfriend, and you still managed to get the information you came for. And! You finally stood up to your mom. God, I wish I had been there for that part, the look she must have had on her face.”

“You didn’t miss much, trust me.” Adora grumbled. Yes she did all those things, but still, nothing had changed, not really. “But…” Adora tore her gaze away, and down to their hands, her touch warm over hers, almost just as real. Catra gave her hand a reassuring squeeze, a thumb ghosting over Adora’s own. “I still don’t feel like I’ve done enough Cat… I don’t know if I ever will.”

“You saved my life, and didn’t even know it.” Catra spoke softly, slipping her free hand into her pocket. A white, gold and blue pom poked out. Adora didn’t know it was there at first, didn’t know she’d been wearing it at all, not until her conversation with Dr. Netossa. In that last photo Catra sent, once she thought to look for it, Adora saw the lump and little pieces of fabric poking out from the pocket of Catra’s leather jacket. “And I love you just enough to have committed that fashion sin. I knew you’d fawn all over the fact I actually wore it to go see you. You did that to me, and I think that’s more than any girl could ask for.”

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“So,” DT said, folding their hands around one of the two fresh cups of coffee between them. “mind telling me what exactly you were doing my sweet *niece?* ”

Adora had her hands balled together inside of the hoodie, down cast eyes focusing on her untouched coffee nurse DT had brought for her. She didn’t know what to say, worried at any moment security was about to come and escort her from the building, never to be allowed to visit again. They’d left her alone in here for around twenty minutes, and Adora assumed it was to make her sweat before an interrogation commenced.

“I doubt that they’d bring you to this break room, claim to be your family, just to rat you out Dor.” Catra said from the empty seat next to her.

“But..” Adora started after glancing her way. She felt herself flush and sunk lower into the chair as DT’s brows rose higher. After spending nearly the last two weeks freely talking with Catra, it was hard to remember that she wasn’t *actually* speaking to anyone. The inside of her cheek was between her teeth. She needed to talk to Cat but couldn’t, she needed Catra, the real one. Adora folded herself further into the too small hoodie, surrounding herself with the comforting smell and closed her eyes. None of this had happened, she was in bed with her, warm, alive and entangled. Adora didn’t need to say anything, she could just go back to her bedroom and stay there forever.

DT sighed and their chair slid back with a loud screech against the floor. Adora squeezed her eyes shut tighter until little stars appeared in the darkness. Catra was brushing her cheek with the back of her hand, whispering about how beautiful she was. “Fine, I’ll just have to assume the worst.” Adora tucked her head under Catra’s chin, kissing the soft spot just above her collarbone. That’s where she could stay forever. Just like when they stayed over at Glimmers, nestled under the blankets, holding on and never letting go. “I get it, you know. I’d probably want my partner to kill me instead of being a vegetable for the rest of my life.”

Adora snapped her eyes open with a snarl. “She is not!” Anger trickled down her shoulders and into clenched fists as she twisted to face the person who would dare call Catra that. “She’s going to wake up, and she’s going to be fine!” Adora’s jaw was so ridged and tight it felt like it might pop any moment now.

DT took the hand that had been reaching for the door and held it up peaceably. “Okay then, I think that answers my main question.”

Catra saw the whites of Adora’s knuckles as they curled over the edge of the table. “Whoa babe. You need chi-“

“No!” Adora jolted back to face Catra. “How dare they! You’re going to be fine, and I’m going to prove it. You just need more time Catra.”

They stayed over by the door, watching silently as Adora huffed and argued with an empty seat. Once the rise and fall of Adora's shoulders calmed and eventually stilled with realization they spoke up again. “I just wanted to make sure you weren’t trying to adjust her meds or send her to an early grave, sweet cheeks.”

Adora leaned forward, resting her head in her hands. She was tired, a bundle of nerves and about three seconds away from bursting into tears. “No one will tell me anything.” She mumbled, unsure and uncaring if the RN even heard her. “I just need to know that she’s going to wake up. It’s been five and half weeks.”

“Well, I made a phone call earlier. Some people are going to come talk to you. I didn’t tell them details, but I figured that was the case. I hope you get what you came for.” Adora turned to them, dazed. DT shrugged at her. “I admire the grit and gumption this took. What can I say, I loved the drama of it all.”

“Are you…” Adora swallowed, fully aware of how unraveled she must look. “Gonna tell them about…”

DT shook their head, long golden locks bouncing behind them. “Do you want to hurt yourself or others?”

“No.” Adora croaked out.

“Then your little Patrick Swazye situation can stay between us darling. Good luck.”

“Ghost. They mean the movie Ghost.” Catra filled in once the nurse had left.

Adora could hear talking outside of the door as she picked nervously at her nails. She kept side eyeing Catra who looked at a loss for what to do with herself. If other people were coming in, Adora had to be careful not to address her, something she’d already failed at multiple times.

Catra stood, her palms against the table and leaned over her, towards her. Adora closed her eyes, so she could pretend Catra swooped down and kissed her on the forehead. “I’ll see you at home babe.” She kept her eyes shut, not wanting to open and be alone again for the first time in days. It seemed she wouldn’t have to be though because there was a gentle knock on the door, followed by it opening immediately after. Adora turned to look and in came a familiar looking woman with long flowing purple hair, hard to forget. She’d seen her before, at the ethics board meetings when the hospital thankfully decided to intervene and keep Beatrix’s influence away from Catra’s care.

“Hello.” She gave Adora a small wave as she stepped in. From the bags under her eyes Adored could tell that she probably had come in earlier than originally expected. “Adora, right?” She said as she closed the door. Adora simply nodded at her. “I’m Spinnerella, or Spinny, whatever you prefer. I’m the social worker here at Krytis hospital. Mind if I join you?” Adora just nodded again, knowing it was just a question of politeness. If DT had told the truth, that they didn’t give details, Adora wasn’t about to put up a fight as long as she could still come here.

She didn’t sit across the table like DT had, instead she sat on the couch pressed against the wall. “Nurse DT said we should talk to

you. I know you're Ms. Weaver's girlfriend, correct?"

Adora didn't have the energy anymore to look at her, the tone she took was obviously rehearsed, a careful conversation she'd had a thousand times before. She just wanted answers, not a check in. Was she okay? Absolutely not, she wasn't going to fool herself anymore after being witnessed talking to air, but she didn't care. There was only one thing she cared about right now.

"Yeah. Catra's my girlfriend." Adora said quietly.

"I can imagine that you've been having a hard time. I'm sorry, but it's kind of a requirement of the job to ask you how you've been feeling, if you're doing okay, and it's absolutely okay if you haven't been. I can guess there's a reason why we're here at..." Spinnerella looked down at her watch. "5:48 in the morning."

"I'm doing fine." Adora replied. Spinnerella didn't look at Adora like she was going to dig, for which Adora was thankful for. "As fine as anyone else would be, I think." She added. "I just… I wanted to… I need to know more about Catra."

Spinnerella nodded, crossing her legs and adjusting until she was in a more casual position. "I'm glad to hear that, but before we leave today, I'm going to give you my card, so that if you ever need someone to talk to, I can get you to the right people. I don't know much about Catra's situation but my wife should be here any moment."

Wife? Adora barely had time to process the word when there was another knock on the door. "Ah, here she is, I think." A sharply dressed woman with a long white coat over top scooted into the room, her arms full of different colored folders.

"Sorry, I'd have been here at the same time dear but I needed to look over some things first." She placed her pile down and joined Spinnerella over by the couch, placing a kiss on the woman's cheek as she did so. Adora was a little taken aback. She'd recognized this woman too, it was the hospital administrator from

that same ethics board. The person who ran the hospital was coming to talk to her, and not because she'd tried to steal patient records? The admin was a gay woman? It's not like Adora hadn't seen other queer couples, there were her friends Scorpia and Perfuma, but seeing two actual *adults* like this was strange. It left her with a both sweet and bitter taste in her mouth.

"Nice to see you again Adora. If you don't recall, I'm Dr. Netossa Aura, the administrator for this hospital. I was told that you came here looking for more information regarding one of our patients?"

"Yes." Adora said dryly, excited that this doctor seemed willing to get straight to the point with her. No more fishing for Adora to talk, no more prodding like from her mother or her friends.

"Regarding Ms. Weaver, while the hospital is responsible for all her medical care and decisions at this time, I still can't just go out and give her information to you. It would be in violation of patient rights without her explicit consent, which she cannot give." The lift that Adora's heart had been feeling puttered out, quickly sinking lower than she thought possible until Netossa gave her a very pointed look.

The doctor plucked a few of the folders from the top of the file and brought them open into her lap. "However, I've recently found myself learning about one of the patients in this wing, and although this patient isn't under my direct care, I think I'd like to discuss this *patient* with my wife. In the abstract of course."

Adora found herself sitting straighter and stiffer in her seat as Netossa spoke. She began to look around the room frantically for something to write things down on when Spinnerella leaned forward with a notepad and pen. "Thank you… thank you so much." Her tongue felt heavy with both anticipation and confusion. "I don't understand though, why…" Adora knew she should be thanking her lucky stars right now but it didn't make sense for her fortune to change like this all of sudden. Before, Adora wasn't even allowed to know the state of her condition

when they brought her to the hospital and was only pressed for information on Catra's mother. Why were loose lips okay now?

"Oh, I'm just discussing a patient, not a particular one." Netossa said casually. "You just happen to be in the break room. That and," Netossa looked at her wife with a weary smile. "we've been together since middle school. Young or not, it's different for people like us. If we hadn't gotten married when we did, before they reversed the legality..."

Spinnerella grabbed Netossa's hand and gave it a firm squeeze and addressed Adora. "If anything happened- I can't imagine not knowing. We're lucky, but that doesn't mean anything here of course, because we're just talking about no one in particular. Understand?"

"Yes! Absolutely 1000% understood." Any tiredness she'd felt was quickly forgotten. Adora uncapped the pen in her hand and tried to quiet the rollercoaster of emotions that had been running through her for the past two hours.

"How much do you want to know?" Netossa asked her. "There might be some things that will be hard to hear."

"Everything." She exhaled without even thinking about it. "I'm tired of not knowing."

"At any point Adora, if you become uncomfortable, say the word and she'll stop." Spinnerella told her, prompting the doctor to begin.

"A patient was brought into the hospital mid February with blunt force trauma to the head after being struck by a vehicle on 8th and central." Netossa's voice was even, clinical, as if presenting a case to a fresh batch of resident doctors. "While she didn't sustain more than a few bruises from the hit itself, this patient unfortunately landed on a rock stuck in the ice next to the roadway."

Adora was just staring down at the blank page of the notepad, nothing had needed to be written down yet but even if there had been, she didn't know if she even could. This was more than she knew, period. She hadn't even known the cause of why Catra was laying still in the hospital instead of planning their summer getaway. A car, a car and rock.

"The patient was unresponsive on scene, according to the responding EMTs the stone hadn't been able to pierce completely during impact thanks to the cushion provided by the toque she was wearing. This was noted due to slower transport time required of them to safely position and transport the patient without causing further injury." Adora inhaled sharply, now aware of just how close Catra had come to not breathing at all.

"The bone surrounding the squamosal suture-" Netossa brought her hand up and tapped just behind her own ear to display the location. "-suffered multiple fractures and in a few places shattered." Adora was watching her, but couldn't actually take in the information that the doctor was saying anymore. Catra didn't usually wear beanies, and didn't own any, usually opting for headbands and a hoodie to keep her ears warm. She didn't like the way they frizzed and flattened her hair, but Adora had gotten her one so she didn't feel obligated to wear something so tacky. She just wanted to get Catra something from their new school.

She caught the important bits from Dr. Aura, like a filter coming through as the movie infront of her played. Of course Catra hasn't walked there in just her jacket and jeans. It was freezing out. "-bruising and bleeding in the brain around the-" Adora could see it. Catra stepped out between snow-buried parked cars, unable to see over the piles and into traffic, or maybe she was just rushing to get to Glimmer's as fast as possible.

The first play through, Catra didn't even notice, head down to watch her step on the slick road. The car hit her and she just simply fell down, blood pooling- "a piece of the skull was removed to relieve pressure from the swelling-" around her head as the light left her eyes. The second one she jogged happily toward the

library, that intersection was where it happened. Had she been coming or going? Did Catra get the book she'd been waiting for?

Catra saw the car coming, had the time to realize her doom, her mouth open and eyes wide in panic and then a sickening crunch, red filling in the spots around the hat Catra had unwrapped in front of her.

Catra tossed the wrapping paper to the ground, trying but failing to hold back her smile. "You dork." Catra sighed, cheeks red as she circled her arms around Adora's neck. "I'm never gonna wear this you, corny ass." Adora leaned in and placed a light kiss on her forehead.

"But it would look so cute, Cat!"

"Surgery lasted twelve hours, no obvious damage to the cerebral tissues from the puncture itself was observed-"

She huffed, and brought her hands up behind Adora, slipping the hat over Adora's face and eyes. "Oh yay!" Catra said snickering. "It'll hide that ridiculous hair poof. Borrow it anytime babe."

The third time Catra was still, just standing there watching the snowfall, observing the world in a way that no one else seemed to, asking questions about the universe she no longer kept to herself. Now that she knew that the world was open to her, that she could change it- "after the first week an additional specialist was called. It isn't unusual following a-"

"Stop!" Adora was startled by the abruptness of her own voice filling the room. She was staring down at the still blank page, the hand holding the pen shaking violently. She grabbed her arm to still it and looked up at the two people who were just there to help her, the two people Adora just yelled at for doing what she'd asked.

They both sat calmly, no pity to be seen from them, just patience. Adora took a deep breath, she still needed information, but not in this way. "What did her EEG say?" That's what was important right

now, the dark that needed to be illuminated for her whiteboard. "Or the PET if you did both. I know on the Glasgow scale, Catra's a three. I know that from my visits. Her pupils dilate, no response to stimulus but she's breathing! She's not brain dead right?! Cat's in there somewhere." Three was the lowest score, had the worst outlook but that assessment still didn't outshine what advanced equipment could tell her.

Netossa shifted uncomfortably and licked her finger, flipping the printed pages. Adora did her best to quell the screaming alarms in her mind. She may not be the best at reading others, but there were cracks in the doctor's placid expression that she didn't like. "Right!?" Adora asked again, her voice cracking.

"There's a lot we still don't know about the nature of comas-"

"Is she brain dead or not?!" Hotness rolled down her cheeks, the pen in her hand creaked as she continued to try and steady her shaking hand, but it wasn't just her hand that was shaking. Adora was shivering like she had when she walked out in that storm, phone still in hand well after the officer hung up.

Netossa furrowed her brows, sifting through the page quickly. "The essential functions are largely perceived to be undamaged so far as has been observed. There's…" her head tilted to the side as she considered something. Adora's throat was tight, swallowing the urge to cross the room and take the folder for herself and running. Netossa looked up at her, expression weighted with an internal conflict. "I don't want to give you any false hope, Adora. The majority of the tests *so far-"* She said the words with heavy emphasis to make sure Adora understood. "-show Catra's mind as *mostly* quiet. This could change as the bruising heals."

"Mostly?" Adora repeated, unsure if she'd heard the doctor wrong.

"Mostly. It looks like Ms. Weaver's hippocampus has been highly reactive during a few of the scans."

It was like time stopped, everything was frozen in place as the meaning took hold and grew branching roots through Adora's veins. The seed of belief she refused to let die blossomed violently inside of her. She didn't hold back anymore, a sob leaving her for the first time in weeks as she rested her head against the cool surface of the table. Air filled her aching chest as she gasped between sudders. Her head was pounding, but she didn't care, she'd ride this pain to get even more information once the dam inside of her was done breaking. Her Catra was still in there. Catra was still there.

It was nearly nine in the morning by the time Adora left the hospital. She'd spent a good hour asking questions about Catra's treatment plan, and discussing Adora's own research, what still applied and what didn't. That number, Catra's odds didn't change. The rest of the brain was void of the usual electric patterns. Spinnerella made Adora promise she'd not spend the whole day there and go home and rest, but she still got a few hours in at Catra's bedside. The number may not have changed, but as Adora watched the holy rise and fall of her chest, she knew that Catra was remembering, remembering something. Netossa had been honest with her, truthful about a fact that Adora already knew. It was unlikely that Catra could hear her, but it didn't hurt to try. Adora could try to make sure it was good memories pouring from that active hippocampus.

Hope didn't greet her at the door when she finally pulled into the garage. Adora knew she was going to be pissed, but that didn't stop the smile that nested under her tired eyes. She almost didn't notice her mother as she passed the kitchen, sitting rigidly at the table with a newspaper in hand. "Where were you?"

"Hospital." It was the truth, and Adora didn't care to explain the bundle of bedding in her arms, the ukulele sitting at the top like a precious jewel.

"Adora, this needs to stop. You can't just go around locking yourself away and sneaking out in the middle of the night. These

actions have consequences. I know you're hurting but do you really think your friend would-"

"Girlfriend." Adora said calmly, looking at her now, her mother, her coach, her life's carefully meticulous curator. "Catra's my girlfriend. I'm going to go back to school tomorrow but you're not telling me what to do anymore Hope. I'm not your property. I'm 18, I'll move out if you want me to, but from now on, you ask." Adora turned from her and headed toward the stairs. "If you try to stop me from seeing her, I'll move out." She stopped at the first step, waiting for some sort of response. "Did I make myself clear?" Hope could try to stop her, argue but in this moment Adora felt like she could do anything. If her mother wanted to debate this though it would have to be another time, there was someone waiting for her in her room.

"I'll put your breakfast in the fridge. Get some rest Adora." Hope said cooly, calmly, as usual.

She was waiting for her, legs criss crossed and sitting at the foot of Adora's bed. Catra leaned forward expectantly as Adora approached, carefully laying her bundle on the bed. "How'd it go?" Cat asked, but Adora stayed silent, crossing back over to her whiteboard. She picked up the eraser, wiping away the dates, and the big red 1:10. Adora grabbed the marker and drew in hard, broad strokes.

She set the marker back into the plastic holder and backed her way to the bed, caring very little about the papers being ruined beneath her feet. She placed herself to sit next to Catra. Adora brought up her girlfriend's newly acquired pillow to her chest and admired the big red 3% now adorning her whiteboard top to bottom. "That bad huh?" Catra asked, shuffling closer to her until they were shoulder to shoulder against the wall.

Adora shook her head and smiled. "No, actually."

Catra furrowed her brows and grunted. "I'm not sure I follow. You know what they say, trouble comes in threes."

“And you’re nothing but trouble.” Adora closed her eyes and buried her face into the pillow. “Stay with me? Until I fall asleep?” She had a feeling Catra’d be gone when she woke up this time. That was okay, because Catra would be okay. She just needed a few more weeks. The odds of waking after the first four weeks in a coma were dim for most. Only about 3% ever recovered when most parts of the brain didn’t buzz with activity. Dr. Aura said it didn’t change Catra’s situation much, but it was still something. And just like that, Adora had a new lucky number, one she’d bet her heart on.

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The Lincoln Continental rumbled to life as she turned the key. Catra leaned her head back mirroring Adora and listened to the motor from her place outside the driver's side door. “I missed that sound.” She said wistfully.

“Me too.” Adora replied just the same, watching the breeze run through Catra’s messy locks, the way the sun made those precious freckles stand out.

“So this is it, huh?” Catra opened her eyes back up and kicked her leg back, lowering herself to lean on the door. “Where too Adora?”

Adora looked over at her spread of directions and smiled. With one swift motion she snatched them all up, curling and crinkling them into a big wad of paper that she threw into the back seat. “I don’t know.” This time, those words didn’t feel like a burden, a decision to be had, they were freeing. “Maps are for braindead’s.” Adora brought her hand up to stop Catra who already had her mouth open to say something snide. “And none of us here are that!”

“Fine…” Catra whined as she rolled her eyes. “Just don’t crash my car, got it? I’ll haunt you until your last breath.” Catra whispered, poking her head through the open window, her lips just a breath away from Adora’s.

“Is that not what you’re doing already?”

“Oh it can and will get worse if you hurt my baby.” Catra teased. “And by baby I mean you too. Have fun Adora. I mean it, go raise hell. Think about yourself for once. You know I’m not going anywhere.” She was so close now, Catra’s nose would press up against her cheek at any moment and they’d collide. “Just… one last thing.” Catra whispered.

Adora closed her eyes and leaned the rest of the way forward. She knew she wouldn’t be able to actually feel it, but she could remember.

Stolen kisses on foreheads and tipsy cheeks because it was the *friendly* thing to do. Their first kiss in the park, hearts hammering away with fear and longing to finally feel each other, to show along as well as tell their love for one another. Hundreds of kisses shared in homes of their friends whose families felt more kin than the ones they were legally bound to. The searing touch of that kiss in the shade of the tree at that clearing in the whispering woods, before the ants staked claim to their leftovers. Catra looked so beautiful laid across the blanket, looking up at her like Adora was the only thing in the world that mattered. How could Adora resist kissing her so passionately as to make sure Catra knew she mattered too? There was also every good morning, good night, panted, moaned and make up kiss that happened in this car. This kiss was a first and Adora vowed it to also be the last of its kind between them. Adora could let herself have one kiss goodbye, for now.

Chapter End Notes

I can’t even stick to my own posting schedule when it’s pre written lmao. Last chapter WILL BE TOMORROW

Edit: here’s some art I did of this chapter https://twitter.com/eat_thee_rude/status/1442318476488609794?s=21

Congruence

Chapter Notes

So, remember the first chapter?

Ps pls read end notes

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora wiped the sweat from her forehead with her damp jersey. At least she had a few minutes to breathe as they lined up to respond to the penalty kick number 17 had drawn out of Lonnie. If she thought her day so far had been a veritable train wreck, this match was a second train ramming right into the debris. Her ribs ached from sneakily thrown elbows, and her ankle throbbed from the front two rubber nubs on one of her cleats tearing. Today was an utterly shit of a day.

Oh, and it rained. There was not even a whisper of a chance for it on the weather forecast. It was like the cloud existed right over campus long enough to dump on them right before half time. The late September heat was sticking around into October so the pitch resembled a muggy swamp. It didn't take long for her change of clothes during halftime to go back to being soaked.

The worst part was the fucking Horde. They played dirty and they played like men. The littlest tap caused them to go tumbling to the ground in pretend agony. If Adora was going to get a fifth yellow card this match, she was going to make it worth it.

Adora ground her teeth as the kick zipped right past Huntara, clean into the right corner. They were down now, 0-2 in their home field. She made eye contact with Huntara as she lined up to cross the ball. Even with Adora's abysmal performance in this game so far, her record proved that she was their best bet to get back in it, even if she'd hit the post three times already.

The cross sailed beautifully toward her. She didn't have time to glare at the referee when no whistle was blown as a body slammed into her back, cleats scraping down her calves, because she still managed to maintain control. Adora spun to see a particularly nasty Horde player ready to cut her off. Adora smirked, guiding the ball up her leg and sent the ball up and over with a Grey signature rainbow kick headed directly to Starla.

She sprinted, leaving the caught off guard defenders behind her, the ones on the other side zipped toward Starla, leaving Adora wide open for a perfect opportunity. The ball was coming her way again, and Adora readied herself, basking in the keeper's panicked expression. The ball was there, she dug her heel in, her leg arched back, then Adora felt the turf under her planted foot curl against the force of her momentum. The tip of Adora's foot struck the ball and sent it sailing. Her eyes never left the ball as she landed ass on heel, the shot flying at least ten feet over the top of the net.

Adora was taking long, deep breaths through her nose, the snickering behind her formulating a wonderful vision of that next card and one game suspension that came with it. The suspension wouldn't matter anyway if they lost this match. Dirt dug into her nails as she curled her fingers into the mucky field. No, she needed to be calm, focused. This day started out bad, her iPod malfunctioning, racing from and back to class, leaving important (hopefully not stolen) items in the car, and now this fucking game. It felt like anything that could happen to her today was happening. What else could possibly go wrong? Adora wouldn't be at all surprised to get to her car afterwards to find it either broken into or with a flat tire. There were big cartoonish anvils of 'fuck with Adora' dropping on her today, but like hell was she going let the Horde get the better of her. With enough focus she could do anything, overcome anything. If she'd let stress break her, Adora would've dropped out the second week of classes, she never would have made it here to begin with. Just keep moving forward.

Once the ball was back in action, Horde quickly moved past their defenses. Adora saw red when she received yet another elbow and uncalled, painful kick against her calf. Starla saw it though and pointed her to the sideline. Starla was good at clearing the ball, and if they were going to score, Adora needed to be able to break away if their opponents were allowed to play dirty. She would wait midfield, cool off, and be ready when the pass came back to her.

Adora dusted the grass and mud off her knees, eyes following the ball on the other side of the pitch as she tried to channel her inner Perfuma. It looked like it was going to be there for a while so she hopefully had the time to find her zenith. Huntara was doing a good job but Horde kept getting possession before they could clear it. There was an itch to run in there, but no, she couldn't do everything. She needed to trust her team and in return she'd go back to being their ace up their sleeve.

Her heart slowed, her vision focused, but over the groans of the crowd something strange was reaching her ears. Adora lurched forward as the ball launched into the air. False alarm. Horde tried for a long shot header but picked it back up anyway. She went back into position, but there was that change in the sound again.

It wasn't odd to hear her name from the crowd, but usually it was "Grey" not Adora. She didn't even have the ball. She tore her attention away from the field and looked into the crowd. It wasn't hard to spot Glimmer and Bow. They were jumping up and down and screaming her name from six rows up. What stunned her though was who was standing between them.

Catra, it had been a while since she'd seen her. Same outfit as always. Leather jacket and tight, black jeans. She was grinning like the Cheshire Cat, standing just behind and between her best friends. Why did her hallucination look so smug? Why was she here at all? Yeah she was having a shit day, the locker room wasn't fun but now that she was out in field it…

Adora could barely hear them, she glanced down the field, the ball was still down there. She cupped her ear, trying to hear what they were trying to say other than just screaming her name repeatedly. Didn't they see that Bright was about to lose this game? What could be so damn important?

Glimmer looked cherry red, like she was about to pop. Bow leaned down and dug into his bag, wiping out a folder and rolling it into a cone shape. Glimmer snatched it and brought it up to her face.

"EVERYONE! SHUT THE FUCK UP!" Her voice pierced the air, the people in the stands around them hushed and turned toward the blue and gold sparkly clad woman, glaring.

Adora was confused, and a lot annoyed if she was being honest. Couldn't whatever this is wait?

Glimmer held her phone up along with the impromptu paper megaphone, and stepped up onto the bench. Catra's face grew impossibly more smug. "MY MOM JUST CALLED ME!"

Adora huffed and rolled her eyes, still trying to keep at least part of the action downfield in view. "OKAY, AND?!" She shouted back. Could this day possibly get anymore-

"SHE'S AWAKE!"

What?

Glimmer screamed the words again. Bow went along with her as they resumed bouncing up and down, arms interlocked. Adora's eyes landed back on Catra, her arms crossed now, lips curling to the side like she'd just bested everyone at board game night. Adora felt her arms go slack.

The hot muggy stadium did nothing to prevent the chill that went through her. She felt the goosebumps rise like waves over her skin. There was no sound, everyone in the crowd became faceless except for Catra, every blur of a person moving in slow motion as those blue and amber eyes held hers. Adora didn't even register the ball rolling past her, out of play. She could hear her though clear as day, Catra.

"Come on dummy."

One of her teammates gripped her shoulder. They were saying something but Adora couldn't make sense of a single word. Catra rolled her eyes and tapped her foot against the bleachers impatiently. Before she could think to use the stairs her hands were at the top of the short wall surrounding the field.

Adora was thankful for the hands of strangers that helped pull her up, her cleats slipping on the wall's surface as she clamored. She rushed toward Glimmer, stepping in between people trying to scoot out of the way of this unstoppable force.

"Keys!" Adora yelled through the lump in her throat, though it came out as more of a screech. Glimmer ended her joy jumping by nearly falling off the seat at Adora's sudden appearance.

"They're in her pocket." Catra said with a wink, pointing at a lump in the Glimmer's shorts. Adora leaned in and quickly dipped a finger and yanked a small ring of keys out of her pocket. Even though her hands were shaking Adora managed to slide off the spare Glimmer kept on her before tossing the set back at her friend. Without another word Adora turned to start sprinting up the steps.

"Adora, wait!" Bow rushed out, grabbing her arm before she could get anywhere.

Adora whipped back around to face them. "You guys, I'm going! I don't care about the-" She stopped when Bow released her arm

and started digging into his pocket. Glimmer was also searching around in her bag.

"Wow, so eager to see me." Catra teased, now walking toward the stairs. "I'll race you to the top Princess." Adora watched her take off on her head start, the cheater, and looked back to see a credit card being shoved into her hand.

"Your stuffs' in the locker room, yeah?" Bow asked, not really needing an answer. "Take this for gas. We'll grab your things as soon as we can and get some clothes and whatnot from your dorm too. We'll just be a few hours behind." Catra could go ahead and beat her up the steps if she wanted because nothing was going to stop Adora from wrapping her friends up into a tight hug. Soccer could suck it, this school could too. Their friends understood what was more important right now. No 'just wait untils'. Bow squeezed her tight from one side and Glimmer kissed her cheek on the other. Adora smiled wide at the indignant noise Catra made from somewhere behind her.

"Drive safe Adora. We'll be there soon too. Tell my sis I can't wait to see her again." Glim mumbled into her shoulder.

"I will. Thank you guys." Adora gave them one last hard squeeze before turning to run like her life depended on it.

Catra had changed her mind about the race and was waiting for her. She had no problem keeping up as they charged up the steps past confused and angry game goers.

"Not even going to change?" She asked, her voice even because this Cat didn't require oxygen and hadn't already played 68 minutes of a rough soccer match.

Adora shook her head, too winded from the hammering in her chest and strain of the stairs to respond. The ache of her ankle was forgotten though as her feet pounded against the concrete, she could feel the adrenaline and a floaty, near god-like feeling bouncing around inside her. Catra was awake. Those words

brought a numbness of a new kind, like watching reality shatter and come back together correctly before her very eyes.

Adora was back on campus grass and well out of the stadium before Catra spoke up again. “Know where you’re going? Got a map?” Adora slowed to a stop and rested on her hands on her shaking knees, panting. As desperately as she wanted to be on the road already her lungs protested. She could afford to catch her breath for just a moment. It was a six hour drive anyway. Five if she couldn’t control herself.

“What do you think?” Adora said between huffs. “I’ve had the way home memorized to come see you since my first day here.”

Catra laughed, shoving her hands in her pockets. She bent down and placed an invisible kiss on Adora’s cheek and backed away toward the stadium. “I’m going to see if these idiots can still win the game without my star player.”

“You’re not coming with?!”

“Nah.” She knew Catra’s grin was a mirror of her own. “I’ll see you in a few hours… drive safe.” She started back toward the stands. “Oh and Adora? Kiss me when you see me okay. I missed you.”

“Obviously.” Adora said with a wild smile as she righted herself, watching this version of her girlfriend become more distant with each step. It didn’t feel right just letting her go like this. The real one was waiting for her, but…

“Hey, Catra?” She whispered, knowing she could hear her no matter the distance. Cat turned around right before the edge of the staircase. “Thank you. Thank you for helping me.. I don’t know if I could have done any of this without you.” Imaginary or not, her own mind or not, this version Catra was the safety belt that ironically kept her sane. She grounded Adora, made her take care of herself, helped her keep going when it felt impossible and this was truly the last time Adora would ever see her again.

Catra smiled at her, shaking her head. "Of course, but Dor, please go to therapy." Catra shrugged her jacket off, draping it over shoulder. She dug into her pocket and pulled out the far too warm for the weather BU hat. The floof at the top jiggled as Catra slipped it on. She looked just as cute as Adora always imagined. "Go team." Cat said drolly with a finger whirl before disappearing down the steps.

She forced herself to walk to the car, now mindful that a leg cramp or side stitch would really put a damper on the journey ahead of her. That beautiful maroon Lincoln was waiting for her with all tires still fully inflated and windows intact. The lock that had become sticky on Melog turned with ease. She'd barely sat down before turning the engine over, the red light for the oil disappeared too. See? Just like a cat, no longer moody now that mom was coming back. Adora sighed with relief to see her phone still rested unstolen in the passenger seat. If it had been gone, she'd have left anyway.

It still didn't feel real, Adora was edging jittery, overwhelming excitement, and unbearable relief to the point where she felt like this was all just a dream. The autopilot would end and at some point she figured it would all come crashing down. She could still drive while crying right? If this was a dream, skipping the enormous 6 hours and seeing Catra before she jolted upright in her bed at the dorm would be nice.

Adora picked up her phone to send a text for Glimmer to grab the ukulele from her dorm when she saw the missed calls. Two were from Angella, the other one was from an unknown number but the same area code. It was from five minutes ago. The phone rang in her hand as she was about to dial it back, it was the same number. She answered immediately.

"Hey kid." When Dr. Aura's voice came through the phone that was apparently all she needed to snap. This was really actually happening and not a magical alternate reality. Something resembling a sob left her throat and it felt like she'd just gotten

kicked in the chest. " *Oh good. Someone was able to reach you. Do you have a few minutes to talk?"*

Adora's head hit the steering wheel as she slumped forward. "Ye-y- yes!" Adora gasped, trying to reign herself back in enough to form a coherent thought or sentence. "She's- she's- Cat's awake? Is-is she alright?"

"Sure is kiddo. She decided to surprise us a few hours ago. We're doing a lot of tests over the next few days but we're giving her a little bit of a break right now."

"Can I talk to her?!"

"That's partially why I'm calling. I'm sure you already know, but it isn't unusual for patients coming out of a coma like this to have some trouble with speech for a while. Catra can hear and is coherent. Any yes or no questions she can answer. We have a blinking system down and I'll be here to translate. It was pretty easy to figure out why she kept looking at the phone in her room though. I told her you'd probably be here soon but you're right, her glare is hard to back down from." Adora's breath was as shaky as the rest of her body was. *"I'm going to put the phone on speaker next to her okay?"*

This was probably the first of many cries that were going to be had today, but hopefully this would see her through for the next few hours so she could actually drive after this call, or maybe she'd just put it on speaker and not hang up until she was with Catra in person. Adora could possibly hold them back long enough to break it up into gas station meltdowns only. There was so much Adora wanted to say, the words jumbling around in her head until through the tears she finally managed a "Catra" before going back to sobbing.

"I think what your girlfriend is trying to say is that she missed you and is very relieved you came back to us."

“Yes! Yes. Yes, god Cat I can’t wait to see you.” There was a noise, a grunt, with a hint of a voice Adora would recognize anywhere that had her somehow crying even harder. Adora closed her eyes, unable to see anything in front of her anyway through the warp of her waterworks. She wasn’t crazy for believing. Even if it had taken years, Adora wouldn’t have stopped believing, but now she didn’t have to. With that 3% Adora had won hundreds of lotteries, and been struck by lightning a dozen times. Catra was back.

“Sss” A hiss-like noise came through the phone with an even more pronounced lilt of Catra’s voice in it. Adora sucked in a breath, forcing her body to stop so she could hear. That sweet voice had her heart pounding, threatening to squeeze itself to a stop. *“Sss. Shhu”* Catra went quiet and growled in frustration.

“Don’t push yourself too hard Catra, it’s okay. It’s going to take some practice.” Netossa told her to which Catra just grunted and resumed anyway.

“Sa. shh. saaa-saal” Adora stilled, soaking in the sound of her voice, trying to figure out the words her love was trying to tell her. It was rough and scratchy, but it was her, really, actually her. Adora lifted her head in realization, wiping the still falling tears from her face and a shaky laugh spilled out as Catra’s efforts continued. Of course that’s what she was trying to say. One word between them that encompasses everything perfectly. The unworldly relief, the joy, the uncertainty gone, and just how badly Adora wanted to kiss her again. With this word it was probably what Cat was feeling too. Just like their first… or maybe it was just because Adora couldn’t stop crying.

“Cat? Are you… are you trying to say… salty?” Adora sniffled, trying not to laugh again so she could hear the answer. The S’s and Sa’s stopped. There was a moment more of silence.

“*Yes* ?” Netossa relayed, confused.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you so much for reading this. I worked on this for months, trying to find the right words and not make it a super corny soap opera coma fic

PLEASE DO SHARE BUT DO NOT SPOIL like… don't even say angst with a happy ending. Let ppl bet their hearts with Adora

Big stupidly fat thank you to my beta readers and the ppl I couldn't shut up to about this. Scorchflame, Sathroe, WildAngeline, Candycornsnake just to name a few and Lologoblens who Beta read the whole damn thing and inspired the ending with a comment that had me rolling on the google doc.

FemboyHimbo / dude.adora on tik tok told me about his Mad Ones Au animatic idea and had me crying at 3 am and I said fuck you, I'm fixing this- and now I did :3 it hurts just as much but it's happy end 😀 🎉 hope the hurt Sammy was yummy.

Gabby… was this SuFFicienTLy painful enough for you? Are you feeling it now Mr. Crabs?

Thanks again! Off to all my WIPs now 😵 💫 and the new "finish b4 posting" (I made it all but 2 chapters finished with Drive so…) NASA wives au fics that my brain went … oh you finished a wip? HAVE ANOTHER

Yell at me on Twitter in addition to comments if you want at @Eat_thee_rude

Pps: I do think Adora is a bit OOC in this at the start- I wanted to show her becoming more her actual self as her friends and (mostly only depicted) catra real and fake helped her come out from Hope's bullshit.

Also, I finally found where I found the stats and grabbed the 3%. I put in my writing notes but forgot to link the paper. There's obviously a bunch of variables but : https://jnnp.bmj.com/content/71/suppl_1/i20

Check out this comic someone did of this fic! (I say someone Bc Twitter handles change) https://twitter.com/ashidafurlen/status/1416090553377337348?s=21

End Notes

In no particular order, here is the playlist. The first song is in there to replace a song that Catra makes up and is a bit of a running joke in the fic, because it's funny.

https://open.spotify.com/playlist/4jsWwRLB5aWr5vId1HcydQ?si=RPuS49-tR4GRr68vmEjJ6g&dl_branch=1

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!